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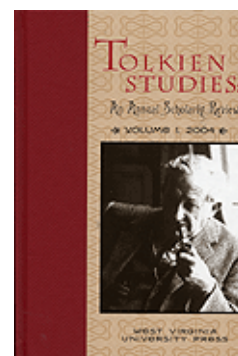
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"The Story of Kullervo" and Essays on Kalevala
"The Kalevala" or Land of Heroes
The Kalevala (Kalervonpoika)

J.R.R. Tolkien
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Notes and Documents

“The Story of Kullervo” and Essays on *Kalevala*

J.R.R. TOLKIEN

Transcribed and edited by Verlyn Flieger

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It has long been known from Tolkien's own comments in his letters that that the Finnish mythology *Kalevala* had a powerful effect on his imagination and his legendarium. Just how powerful is strikingly apparent in “The Story of Kullervo” and the two drafts of “On the Kalevala,” all three here published for the first time. Both the story and the essay provide substantial evidence of Tolkien's early enthusiasm for and desire to communicate the unfettered exuberance, the unspoiled pagan quality, and what he called the “delicious exaggerations” of what were to him “wild . . . uncivilized and primitive tales.” At the time Tolkien was writing, Elias Lönnrot's compilation of Finnish folk-ballads was a relatively recent addition to the world's mythological literature. Tolkien first discovered the *Kalevala* through Kirby's English translation in 1911, when he was at King Edward's School in Birmingham. When he went up to Oxford in the fall of that year, he checked out a Finnish grammar from the Exeter College Library hoping to read the *Kalevala* in the original, which hope was largely frustrated (see essay “On the Kalevala,” section I, paragraph 4).

While working on his degree at Oxford in October of 1914 he wrote to his future wife (then fiancée) Edith Bratt that he was “trying to turn one of the stories [of the *Kalevala*]¹—which is really a very great story and most tragic—into a short story somewhat on the lines of Morris' romances with chunks of poetry in between” (*Letters* 7). Although he never finished it, Tolkien later gave this story credit as being “the original germ of the Silmarillion” (*Letters* 87), since it became transformed into the tale of Túrin Turambar, the epic, tragic hero of Tolkien's own mythology. “The Story of Kullervo” presents Tolkien's treatment of a figure who has had many incarnations ranging from the medieval Icelandic Amleth to the Danish Amlethus of Saxo Grammaticus's *Gesta Danorum* to Shakespeare's moody, erratic, vengeful Renaissance Prince Hamlet, and culminating in the Finnish Kullervo to whom Tolkien is most indebted.

The narrative trajectory of Tolkien's story follows *Runos* 31-36 in the *Kalevala*. These tell of a quarrel between brothers which leaves one dead, the other the murderous guardian of the dead brother's newborn son

Kullervo. The boy grows up to exact revenge for his family's destruction but is himself destroyed by his discovery of his unwitting incest with a sister he did not recognize. Tolkien's story follows its source closely; its main departure is in the matter of names. He began by following the *Kalevala* nomenclature, but subsequently changed to his own invented names or nicknames for all but the major characters, Kalervo, Kullervo, and Untamo; and even for these he supplied a variety of nicknames. His text is not always consistent, however, and he occasionally reverts to, or forgets to change, an earlier discarded name. His use of diacritical marks over the vowel—chiefly macrons but also occasionally breves—is also somewhat random. In regularizing his usage, I have made the present transcript more consistent in this regard than is the actual text. Tolkien's most notable change is from "Ilmarinen," the name of the smith in *Kalevala*, to "Äsemo" (see the entry for Äsemo the smith in the Notes and Commentary for a longer discussion on the etymology of the name).

"The Story of Kullervo" exists in a single manuscript, Bodleian Library MS Tolkien B 64/6. This is a legible but rough draft, with many crossings-out, marginal and above-line additions, corrections, and emendations. The text is written in pencil on both sides of 13 numbered bifold foolscap folios. The main narrative breaks off abruptly halfway down the recto of folio 13, at a point about three quarters through the story. It is followed on the same page by notes and outlines for the remainder, which fill the rest of the space and continue onto the top portion of the verso. There are in addition several loose sheets of variable size containing what are clearly preliminary plot outlines, jotted notes, lists of names, lists of rhyming words, and several drafts of one verse section of the story, "Now in sooth a man I deem me." If, as appears likely, Tolkien B 64/6 contains the earliest and (aside from the note pages) the only draft of the story, Tolkien's revisions on this manuscript must stand as his final ones.

I have left Tolkien's sometimes quirky usage and often convoluted syntax intact, in a few instances adding punctuation to clarify meaning. Square brackets enclose words missing from the text but supplied for clarity. False starts, cancelled words and lines have been omitted, with three exceptions. In these instances, wavy brackets enclose phrases or sentences cancelled in the MS but here retained as of interest to the story. These are: 1) "when magic was yet new"; 2) "and to Kullervo he gave three hairs . . ."; and 3) "I was small and lost my mother . . .". I have preferred not to interrupt the text (and distract the reader) with note numbers, but a Notes and Commentary section follows the narrative proper, explaining terms and usage, citing references, and clarifying the relationship of Tolkien's story to its *Kalevala* source. This section also includes Tolkien's preliminary outline notes for the story, enabling the reader to track changes and follow the path of Tolkien's developing imagination.

Unlike the story, Tolkien’s essay on the *Kalevala* exists in two states, one a manuscript and the other a typescript, both catalogued together as Bodleian Library MS Tolkien B61. The manuscript, in ink over pencil and heavily emended, consists of fourteen closely-written but not always consecutive pages plus an additional, smaller page (not included here) containing fragmentary jotted notes. The typescript, which has only occasional emendations in ink, comprises nineteen single-spaced pages, and breaks off in mid-sentence at the bottom of page 19.

The hand-written title page to the manuscript which reads “On ‘The Kalevala’ or Land of Heroes,” also bears the notations “(C.C. Coll. [Corpus Christi College] Oxford ‘Sundial’ Nov. 1914)” and “Exeter Coll. Essay Club. Feb. 1915,” the two dates on which Tolkien is known to have delivered the talk. The November 1914 presentation, a bare month after his letter to Edith, and the February one a scant three months later, clearly belong to the same period as the story. No firm date can be assigned for the somewhat revised typescript draft, which has no separate title page, but only the heading “The Kalevala.” A reference in the text to the “late war” would place it after the Armistice of November 11, 1918, and an allusion to the “League” (presumably the League of Nations formed in 1919-1920) would make 1919 a terminus a quo. On the basis of comparison with material in Tolkien’s early poetry manuscripts and typescripts Douglas A. Anderson suggests 1919-21 (personal communication), while Christina Scull and Wayne Hammond propose a somewhat later, admittedly conjectural dating of “?1921-24?” (*Chronology*, 115). Anderson’s date would place the revision at a time when Tolkien was still in Oxford (he was on the staff of the New English Dictionary from November 1918 to the spring of 1920), while the Scull-Hammond time frame would push it to the period when Tolkien was Reader in English Language at Leeds University. In either case, there is no evidence that this revised talk was ever given.

As with “The Story of Kullervo,” I have edited the essays’ transcriptions for smooth reading. Square brackets enclose words missing from the text but supplied where necessary for clarity. False starts, cancelled words and lines have been omitted. Also as with the story, I have chosen not to interrupt the text (and distract the reader) with note numbers, but a Notes and Commentary section follows each essay proper, explaining terms and usage, and citing references.

A Note On Names

It has been pointed out to me by Carl Hostetter that some of the invented names in “The Story of Kullervo” echo or prefigure Tolkien’s earliest known efforts at his invented language Qenya. Qenya-like names in the story include the god-names *Ilu*, *Ilukko* and *Ilwinti*, strongly remi-

niscent of the Silmarillion's godhead figure *Ilúwatar*. Kullervo's nickname *Kampa* appears in early Qenya as a name for Earendel with the meaning "Leaper." The place-name *Kēme*, *Kēmēnūma*, in Tolkien's story glossed as "The Great Land, Russia," is in Qenya "earth, soil". The place-name *Tē-lea* (Karelja) evokes the Teleri of the Silmarillion, one of the three groups of elves to go to Valinor from Middle-earth. *Manalome*, *Manatomi*, *Manoini*, "sky, heaven," recall Qenya *Mana/Manwë*, chief of the Valar, the demigods of the Silmarillion. One can only speculate as to the chronological relationship between the names in "The Story of Kullervo" and Tolkien's burgeoning Qenya, the earliest evidences for which are contained in the Qenya Lexicon, a notebook bearing no date, but apparently written in 1915-16. For a more extended look at the development of Qenya see Tolkien's "Qenyaqetsa: The Qenya Phonology and Lexicon," published in *Parma Eldalamberon* XII, 1998.

The Story of Honto Taltewenlen

The Story of Kullervo (Kalervonpoika)

In the days long ago {when magic was yet new}, a swan nurtured her brood of cygnets by the banks of a smooth river in the reedy marshland of Sutse. One day as she was sailing among the sedge-fenced pools with her trail of younglings following, an eagle swooped from heaven and flying high bore off one of her children to Telea: on the second day a mighty hawk robbed her of yet another and bore it to Kemenūme. Now that nursling that was brought to Kemenūme waxed and became a trader and cometh not into this sad tale: but that one whom the hawk brought to Telea he it is whom men name Kalervo: while a third of the nurslings that remained behind is he men speak oft of and name him Untamo the evil, and a fell sorcerer and man of power did he become.

And Kalervo dwelt beside the rivers of fish and had thence much sport and good meat, and with him had his wife borne in years past both a son and a daughter and was even now again nigh to childbirth. And in those days did Kalervo's lands border on the confines of the dismal realm of his mighty brother Untamo; who coveted his pleasant river lands and its plentiful fish. So coming he set nets in Kalervo's fish water and robbed Kalervo of his angling and brought him great grief. And bitterness arose between the brothers, first that and at last open war. After a fight upon the river banks in which neither might overcome the other, Untamo returned to his grim homestead and sat in evil brooding, weaving in his fingers a design of wrath and vengeance.

He caused his mighty cattle to break into Kalervo’s pastures and drive his sheep away and devour their fodder. Then Kalervo let forth his black hound Musti to devour them. Untamo then in ire mustered his men and gave them weapons; armed his henchmen and slave lads with axe and sword and marched to battle, even to ill strife against his very brother.

And the wife of Kalervoinen sitting nigh to the window of the homestead descried a scurry arising of the smoke army in the distance, and she spake to Kalervo saying, “Husband lo an ill reek ariseth yonder: come hither to me. Is it smoke I see or but some gloomy cloud that passeth swift but now hovers on the borders of the cornfields just yonder by the new-made pathway.” Then said Kalervo in heavy mood, “Yonder, wife, is no reek of autumn smoke nor any passing gloom, but I fear me a cloud that goeth nowise swiftly nor before it has harmed my house and folk in evil storm.” Then there came into the view of both Untamo’s assemblage and ahead could they see the numbers and their strength and their gay scarlet raiment. Steel shimmered there and at their belts were their swords hanging and in their hands their stout axes gleaming and neath their caps their ill faces lowering; for ever did Untamoinen gather to him cruel and worthless carles.

And Kalervo’s men were out and about the farm lands so seizing axe and shield he rushed on his foes and was soon slain even in his own yard nigh to the cowbyre in the autumn-sun of his own fair harvest-tide by the weight of the numbers of foemen. Evilly Untamoinen wrought with his brother’s body before his wife’s eyes and foully entreated his folk and lands. His wild men slew all whom they found both man and beast, sparing only Kalervo’s wife and her two children and sparing them thus only to bondage in his gloomy halls of Untola.

Bitterness then entered the heart of that mother, for Kalervo had she dearly loved and dear been to him and she dwelt in the halls of Untamo caring naught for anything in the sunlit world: and in due time bore amidst her sorrow Kalervo’s babes: a man-child and a maid-child at one birth. Of great strength was the one and of great fairness the other even at birth and dear to one another from their first hours: but their mother’s heart was dead within, nor did she reck aught of their goodness nor did it gladden her grief or do better than recall the old days in their homestead of the smooth river and the fish waters among the reeds and the thought of the dead Kalervo their father, and she named the boy Kullervo, or “wrath,” and his daughter Wānōna, or “weeping.” And Untamo spared the children for he thought they would wax to lusty servants and he could have them do his bidding and tend his body nor pay them the wages he paid the other uncouth carles. But for lack of their mother’s care the children were reared in crooked fashion for ill cradle rocking

meted to infants by fosterers in thralldom: and bitterness do they suck from breasts of those that bore them not.

The strength of Kullervo unsoftened turned to untameable will that would forego naught of his desire and was resentful of all injury. And a wild lone-faring maiden did Wānōna grow, straying in the grim woods of Untola so soon as she could stand—and early was that, for wondrous were these children and but one generation from the men of magic. And Kullervo was like to her: an ill child he ever was to handle till came the day that in wrath he rent in pieces his swaddling clothes and kicked with his strength his linden cradle to splinters—but men said that it seemed he would prosper and make a man of might and Untamo was glad, for him thought he would have in Kullervo one day a warrior of strength and a henchman of great stoutness.

Nor did this seem unlike, for at the third month did Kullervo, not yet more than knee-high, stand up and spake in this wise on a sudden to his mother who was grieving still in her yet green anguish. “O my mother, O my dearest why grieveest thou thus?” and his mother spake unto him telling him the dastard tale of the Death of Kalervo in his own homestead and how all he had earned was ravished and slain by his brother Untamo and his underlings, and nought spared or saved but his great hound Musti who had returned from the fields to find his master slain and his mistress and her children in bondage, and had followed their exile steps to the blue woods round Untamo’s halls where now he dwelt a wild life for fear of Untamo’s men and ever and anon slaughtered a sheep and often at the night could his baying be heard: and Untamo’s underlings said it was the hound of Tuoni Lord of Death though it was not so.

All this she told him and gave him a great knife curious wrought that Kalervo had worn ever at his belt if he fared afield, a blade of marvelous keenness made in his dim days, and she had caught it from the wall in the hope to aid her dear one. Thereat she returned to her grief and Kullervo cried aloud “By my father’s knife when I am bigger and my body waxeth stronger then will I avenge his slaughter and atone for the tears of my mother who bore me.” And these words he never said again but that once, but that once did Untamo overhear. And for wrath and fear he trembled and said, he will bring my race in ruin, for Kalervo is reborn in him.

And therewith he devised all manner of evil for the boy (for so already did the babe appear, so sudden and so marvelous was his growth in form and strength) and only his twin sister the fair maid Wānōna (for so already did she appear, so great and wondrous was her growth in form and beauty) had compassion on him and was his companion in their wandering the blue woods: for their elder brother and sister (of which tale told before), though they had been born in freedom and looked on

their father's face, were more like unto thralls than those orphans born in bondage, and knuckled under to Untamo and did all his evil bidding nor in anything recked to comfort their mother who had nurtured them in the rich days by the river.

And wandering in the woods a year and a month after their father Kalervo was slain these two wild children fell in with Musti the Hound. Of Musti did Kullervo learn many things concerning his father and Untamo and of things darker and dimmer and farther back even perhaps before their magic days and even before men as yet had netted fish in Tuoni the marshland. Now Musti was the wisest of hounds: nor do men say ever aught of where or when he was whelped but ever speak of him as a dog of fell might and strength and of great knowledge, and Musti had kinship and fellowship with the things of the wild, and knew the secret of the changing of skin and could appear as wolf or bear or as cattle great or small, and could much other magic besides.

And on the night of which it is told, the hound warned them of the evil of Untamo's mind and that he desired nothing so much as Kullervo's death {and to Kullervo he gave three hairs from his coat, and said, "Kullervo Kalervanpoika, if ever you are in danger from Unto take one of these and cry 'Musti O! Musti may thy magic aid me now', then wilt thou find a marvellous aid in thy distress."}

And next day Untamo had Kullervo seized and crushed into a barrel and flung into the waters of a rushing torrent—that seemed like to be the waters of Tuoni the River of Death to the boy: but when they looked out upon the river three days after, he had freed himself from the barrel and was sitting upon the waves fishing with a rod of copper with a silken line for fish, and he ever remained from that day a mighty catcher of fish. Now this was done by the magic of Musti.

And again did Untamo seek Kullervo's destruction and sent his servants to the woodland where they gathered mighty birch trees and pine trees from which the pitch was oozing, pine trees with their thousand needles, sledgefuls of bark did he draw together, great ash trees, and all this they heaped for the burning of Kullervo. They kindled the flame beneath the wood and the great bale-fire crackled and the smell of logs and acrid smoke choked them wondrously and then the whole blazed up in red heat and thereat they thrust Kullervo in the midst and the fire burned for two days and a third day and then sat there the boy knee-deep in ashes and up to his elbows in embers and a silver coal-rake he held in his hand and gathered the hottest fragments around him and himself was unscathed.

Untamo then in blind rage seeing that all his sorcery availed nought had him hanged shamefully on a tree. And there the child of his brother Kalervo dangled high from a great oak for two nights and a third night

and then Untamo sent at dawn to see whether Kullervo was dead upon the gallows or no. And his servant returned in fear: and such were his words: "Lord, Kullervo has in no wise perished as yet: nor is dead upon the gallows, but in his hand he holdeth a great knife and has scored wondrous things therewith upon the tree and all its bark is covered with carvings wherein chiefly is to be seen a great fish (now this was Kalervo's sign of old) and wolves and bears and a huge hound such as might even be one of the great pack of Tuoni." Now this magic that had saved Kullervo's life was the last hair of Musti: and the knife was the great knife Sikki: his father's, which his mother had given to him: and thereafter Kullervo treasured the knife Sikki beyond all silver and gold.

Untamoinen felt afraid and yielded perforce to the great magic that guarded the boy, and sent him to become a slave and to labour for him without pay and but scant fostering: indeed often would he have starved but for Wānōna who, though Unti treated her scarcely better, spared her brother much from her little. No compassion for these twins did their elder brother and sister show, but sought rather by subservience to Unti to get easier life for themselves: and a great resentment did Kullervo store up for himself and daily he grew more morose and violent and to no one did he speak gently but to Wānōna and not seldom was he short with her.

So when Kullervo had waxed taller and stronger Untamo sent for him and spake thus: "In my house I have retained you and meted wages to you as methought thy bearing merited—food for thy belly or a buffet for thy ear: now must thou labour and thrall's or servant's work will I appoint for you. Go now, make me a clearing in the near thicket of the Blue Forest. Go now." And Kuli went. But he was not ill pleased, for though of but two years he deemed himself grown to manhood in that now he had an axe set in hand, and he sang as he fared him to the woodlands.

Song of Sākehonto in the woodlands.

Now in sooth a man I deem me
Though mine ages have seen few summers
And this springtime in the woodlands
Still is new to me and lovely.
Nobler am I now than erstwhile
And the strength of five within me
And the valour of my father
In the springtime in the woodlands
Swells within me Sākehonto.
O mine axe my dearest brother
Such an axe as fits a chieftain
Lo we go to fell the birch-trees

And to hew their white shafts slender:
For I ground thee in the morning
And at even wrought a handle;
And thy blade shall smite the tree-boles
And the wooded mountains waken
And the timber crash to earthward
In the springtime in the woodland
Neath thy stroke mine iron brother.

And thus fared Sākehonto to the forest slashing at all that he saw to the right or to the left, him recking little of the wrack, and a great tree-swathe lay behind him for great was his strength. Then came he to a dense part of the forest high up on one of the slopes of the mountains of gloom, nor was he afraid for he had affinity with wild things and Musti's magic was about him, and there he chose out the mightiest trees and hewed them, felling the stout at one blow and the weaker at a half. And when seven mighty trees lay before him on a sudden he cast his axe from him that it half cleft through a great oak that groaned thereat: but the axe there quivering.

But Sake shouted, "May Tanto Lord of Hell do such labour and send Lempo for the timbers fashioning." And he sang:

Let no sapling sprout here ever
Nor the blades of grass stand greening
While the mighty earth endureth
Or the golden moon is shining
And its rays come filtering dimly
Through the boughs of Saki's forest.
Now the seed to earth hath fallen
And the young corn shooteth upward
And its tender leaf unfoldeth
Till the stalks do form upon it.
May it never come to earing
Nor its yellow head droop ripely
In this clearing in the forest
In the woods of Sakehonto.

And within a while came forth Ūlto to gaze about him to learn how the son of Kampo his slave had made a clearing in the forest but he found no clearing but rather a ruthless hacking here and there and a spoilage of the best of trees: and thereon he reflected saying, "For such labour is the knave unsuited, for he has spoiled the best timber and now I know not whither to send him or to what I may set him. "

But he bethought him and sent the boy to make a fencing betwixt

some of his fields and the wild; and to this work Honto set out but he gathered the mightiest of the trees he had felled and hewed thereto others: firs and lofty pines from blue Puhōsa and used them as fence stakes; and these he bound securely with rowan and wattled: and made the tree-wall continuous without break or gap: nor did he set a gate within it nor leave an opening or chink but said to himself grimly, "He who may not soar swift aloft like a bird nor burrow like the wild things may never pass across it or pierce through Honto's fence work."

But this over-stout fence displeased Ūlto and he chid his slave of war for the fence stood without gate or gap beneath, without chink or crevice resting on the wide earth and towering amongst Ukko's clouds above. For this do men call a lofty Pine ridge "Sāri's hedge."

"For such labour," said Ūlto, "art thou unsuited: nor know I to what I may set thee, but get thee hence, there is rye for threshing ready." So Sāri got him to the threshing in wrath and threshed the rye to powder and chaff that the winds of Wenwe took it and blew as a dust in Ūlto's eyes, whereat he was wroth and Sāri fled. And his mother was feared for that and Wānōna wept, but her brother and elder sister chid them for they said that Sāri did nought but make Ūlto angered and of that anger's ill did they all have a share while Sāri skulked the woodlands. Thereat was Sāri's heart bitter, and Ūlto spake of selling as a bond slave into a distant country and being rid of the lad.

His mother spoke then pleading, "O Sārihonto if you fare abroad, if you go as a bond slave into a distant country, if you perish among unknown men, who will have thought for thy mother or daily tend the hapless dame?" And Sāri in evil mood answered singing out in light heart and whistling thereto:

Let her starve upon a haycock
Let her stifle in the cowbyre

And thereto his brother and sister joined their voices saying

Who shall daily aid thy brother?
Who shall tend him in the future?

To which he quoting his answer

Let him perish in the forest
or lie fainting in the meadow.

And his sister upbraided him saying he was hard of heart, and he made answer. "For thee treacherous sister though thou be a daughter of Keime I care not: but I shall grieve to part from Wānōna."

Then he left them and Ūlto thinking of the lad's size and strength

relented and resolved to set him yet other tasks, and is it told how he went to lay his largest drag-net and as he grasped his oar asked aloud, “Now shall I pull amain with all my vigour or with but common effort?” And the steersman said “Row now amain, for thou canst not pull this boat atwain.”

Then Sāri Kampa’s son rowed with all his might and sundered the wood rowlocks and shattered the ribs of juniper and the aspen planking of the boat he splintered. Quoth Ūlto when he saw, “Nay, thou understandst not rowing, go thresh the fish into the dragnet: maybe to more purpose wilt thou thresh the water with threshing-pole than with foam.” But Sāri as he was raising his pole asked aloud, “Shall I thresh amain with many vigour or but leisurely with common effort threshing with the pole?” And the net-man said, “Nay, thresh amain. Wouldst thou call it labour if thou threshed not with thy might but at thine ease only?” So Sāri threshed with all his might and churned the water to soup and threshed the net to tow and battered the fish to slime. And Ūlto’s wrath knew no bounds and he said, “Utterly useless is the knave: whatsoever work I give him he spoils from malice: I will sell him as a bond-slave in the Great Land. There the Smith Āsemo will have him that his strength may wield the hammer.”

And Sāri wept in wrath and in bitterness of heart for his sundering from Wānōna and the black dog Musti. Then his brother said, “Not for thee shall I be weeping if I hear thou has perished afar off. I will find himself [myself?] a brother better than thou and more comely too to see.” For Sāri was not fair in the face but swart and illfavoured and his stature assorted not with his breadth. And Sāri said,

Not for you shall I go weeping
If I hear that thou hast perished:
I will make me such a brother —

with great ease: with a head of stone and a mouth of sallow, and his eyes shall be cranberries and his hair of withered stubble: and legs of willow twigs I’ll make him and his flesh of rotten trees I’ll fashion—and even so he will be more a brother and better than thou art.

And his elder sister asked whether he was weeping for his folly and he said nay, for he was fain to leave her and she said that for her part she would not grieve at his sending nor even did she hear he had perished in the marshes and vanished from the people, for so she should find herself a brother and one more skilful and more fair to boot. And Sāri said, “Nor for you shall I go weeping if I hear that thou hast perished. I can make me such a sister out of clay and reeds with a head of stone and eyes of cranberries and ears of water lily and a body of maple, and a better sister than thou art.”

Then his mother spake to him soothingly

Oh my sweet one O my dearest
I the fair one who has borne thee
I the golden one who nursed thee
I shall weep for thy destruction
If I hear that thou hast perished
And hast vanished from the people.
Scarce thou knowest a mother's feelings
Or a mother's heart it seemeth
And if tears be still left in me
For my grieving for thy father
I shall weep for this our parting
I shall weep for thy destruction
And my tears shall fall in summer
And still hotly fall in winter
Till they melt the snows around me
And the ground is bared and thawing
And the earth again grows verdant
And my tears run through the greenness.
O my fair one O my nursling
Kullervoinen Kullervoinen
Sarihonto son of Kampa.

But Sāri's heart was black with bitterness and he said, "Thou wilt weep not and if thou dost, then weep: weep till the house is flooded, weep until the paths are swimming and the byre a swell, for I reck not and shall be far hence." And Sārihonto son of Kampa did Ūlto take abroad with him and brought to the land of Telea where dwelt Āsemo the smith, nor did Sāri see aught of Wānōna at his parting and that hurt him: but Musti followed him afar off and his baying in the nighttime brought some cheer to Sāri and he had still his knife Sikki.

And the smith, for he deemed Sāri a worthless knave and uncouth, gave Ūlto but two outworn kettles and five old rakes and six scythes in payment and with that Ūlto had to return home contented.

And now did Sāri drink not only the bitter draught of thralldom and eat the poisoned bread of solitude and loneliness thereto: and he grew more ill favoured and crooked, broad and knotty and unrestrained and unsoftened, and fared often into the wild wastes with Musti: and grew to know the fierce wolves and to converse even with Uru the bear: nor did such comrades improve his mind and the temper of his heart, but never did he forget in the deep of his mind his vow of long ago and wrath with Ūlto, but no tender feelings would he let his heart cherish for his folk afar save at whiles for Wānōna.

Now Āsemo had to wife the daughter [of] Koi Queen of the marshlands of the north, whence he carried magic and many other dark things to Puhōsa and even to Sutsi by the broad rivers and the reed-fenced pools. She was fair but to Āsemo alone sweet. Treacherous and hard and little love did she bestow on the uncouth thrall and little did Sāri bid for her love or kindness.

Now as yet Āsemo set not his new thrall to any labour for he had men enough, and for many months did Sāri wander in wildness till at the egging of his wife the smith bade Sāri became his wife’s servant and do all her bidding. And then was Koi’s daughter glad for she trusted to make use of his strength to lighten her labour about the house and to punish him for his slights and roughness towards her aforetime.

But as may be expected, he proved an ill bondservant and great dislike for Sāri grew up in his [Āsemo’s] wife’s heart and no spite she could wreak against him did she ever forego. And it came to a day many and many a summer since Sāri was sold out of Puhōsa and left the blue woods and Wānōna, that seeking to rid the house of his hulking presence the wife of Āsemo pondered deep and bethought her to set him as her herdsman and send him afar to tend her wide flocks in the open lands about.

Then set she herself to baking; and in malice did she prepare the food for the neatherd to take with him. Grimly working to herself she made a loaf and a great cake. Now the cake she made of oats below with a little wheat above it, but between she inserted a mighty flint—saying the while, “Break thou the teeth of Sāri O flint: rend thou the tongue of Kampa’s son that speaketh always harshness and knows of no respect to those above him.” For she thought how Sāri would stuff the whole into his mouth at a bite, for greedy he was in manner of eating, not unlike the wolves his comrades.

Then she spread the cake with butter and upon the crust laid bacon and calling Sāri bid him go and tend the flocks that day nor return until evening, and the cake she gave him as his allowance, bidding him eat not until the herd was driven into the wood. Then sent she Sāri forth, saying after him:

Let him herd among the bushes
And the milch kine in the meadow:
These with wide horns to the aspens
These with curved horns to the birches
That they thus may fatten on them
And their flesh be sweet and goodly
Out upon the open meadows
Out among the forest borders
Wandering in the birchen woodland

And the lofty growing aspens
Lowing now in silver copses
Roaming in the golden firwoods.

And as her great herds and the herdsman got them afar, some thought
belike of foreboding seized her and she prayed to Ilu the God of Heaven
who is good and dwells in Manatomi. And her prayer was in the fashion
of a song and very long, whereof some was thus:

Guard my kine O gracious Ilu
From the perils in the pathway
That they come not into danger
Nor may fall on evil fortune.
If my herdsman is an ill one
Make the willow then a neatherd
Let the alder watch the cattle
And the mountain ash protect them
Let the cherry lead them homeward
In the milktide in the even.
If the willow will not herd them
Nor the mountain ash protect them
And the alder will not watch them
Nor the cherry drive them homeward
Send thou then thy better servants,
Send the daughters of Ilwinti
To guard my kine from danger
And protect my horned cattle
For a many are thy maidens
At thy bidding in Manoine
And skilled to herd the white kine
On the blue meads of Ilwinti
Until Ukko comes to milk them
And gives drink to thirsty Kēme.
Come thou maidens great and ancient
Mighty daughters of the Heaven
Come thou children of Malōlō
At Ilukko's mighty bidding
O [illegible] most wise one
Do thou guard my flock from evil
Where the willows will not ward them
Out across the quaking marshland
Where the surface ever shifteth
And the greedy depths are gulping.
O thou Sampia most lovely

Blow the honey horn most gaily.
Where the alder will not tend them
Do thou pasture all my cattle
Making flowers upon the hummocks
With the melody of the mead-horn
Make thou fair this heathland border
And enchant the skirting forest
That my kine have food and fodder,
And have golden hay in plenty
And the heads of silver grasses.
O Palikki's little damsel
And Telenda her companion
Where the rowan will not tend them
Dig my cattle wells all silver
Down on both sides of the pasture.
With your straying feet of magic
Cause the grey springs to spout coolly
And the streams that flow by swiftly
And the speedy running rivers
Twixt the shining banks of grassland
To give drink of honey sweetness
That the herd may suck the water
And the juice may trickle richly
To their swelling teeming udders
And the milk may flow in runlets
And may foam in streams of whiteness.
But Kaltūse thrifty mistress
And arrester of all evil,
Where the wild things will not guard them
Fend the sprite of ill far from them
That no idle hands do milk them
And their milk on earth be wasted
That no drops flow down to Pūlu
And that Tanto drink not of it,
But that when at Kame at milk tide
Then their milkstreams may be swollen
And the pails be overflowing
And the good wife's heart be gladdened.
O Terenye maid of Samyan
Little daughter of the forest
Clad in soft and beauteous garments
With thy yellow hair so lovely
And thy shoon of scarlet leather,

When the cherry will not lead them
Be their neatherd and their shepherd
When the sun to rest has sunken
And the bird of eve is singing,
As the twilight draweth closer
Speak thou to my horned creatures
Saying come ye hoofed cattle
Come ye homeward trending homeward.
In the house 'tis glad and pleasant
Where the floor is sweet for resting
On the waste 'tis ill to wander
Lowing down the empty shorelands
Of the many lakes of Sutsi.
Therefore come ye horned creature
And the women fire will kindle
In the field of honeyed grasses
On the ground o'ergrown with berries.

[*The following lines are offset to indicate a change of tone. Kirby's edition does not so distinguish them, but notes in the Argument at the head of the Runo that it contains "the usual prayers and charms" (Kirby Vol. 2, p. 78). Magoun gives the lines the heading "Charms for Getting Cattle Home, Lines 273-314" (Magoun, p. 232). Ed.]*

Then Pelikki's little damsel
And Telenda her companion
Take a whip of birch to scourge them
And of juniper to drive them
From the hold of Sanya's cattle
And the gloomy slopes of alder
In the milktide of the evening,

[*As above, these lines are offset to indicate a shift in tone and separate them from those preceding. Kirby's Argument notes a charm for "protection from bears in the pastures" (78), while Magoun supplies the heading "Admonitory Charms Against Bears, Lines 315-542 (p. 232). Ed.]*

O thou Uru O my darling
My Honeypaw that rules the forest
Let us call a truce together
In the fine days of the summer
In the good Creator's summer
In the days of Ilu's laughter
That thou sleepest upon the meadow
With thine ears thrust into stubble

Or conceal thee in the thickets
That thou mayst not hear cowbells
Nor the talking of the herdsman.
Let the tinkling and the lowing
And the ringing in the heathland
Put no frenzy yet upon thee
Nor thy teeth be seized with longing.
Rather wander in the marshes
And the tangle of the forest.
Let thy growl be lost in wastelands
And thy hunger wait the season
When in Samyan is the honey
All fermenting on the hillslopes
Of the golden land of Kēme
Neath the faring bees a-humming.
Let us make this league eternal
And an endless peace between us
That we live in peace in summer,
In the good Creator’s summer.

[As with the other separations, this indentation is offset to indicate change in tone, in this case the conclusion or peroration of the lady’s prayers. Neither Kīrby nor Magoun so distinguishes these lines. Ed.]

All this prayer and all this chanting
O then Ukko silver monarch
Hearken to my sweet entreaty.
Bind in leash the dogs of Kūru
And enchain the forest wild things
And in Ilwe set the Sun-star
And let all the days be golden.

Now Āsemo’s wife was a great chanter of prayers—and also a most grasping woman and over heedful of her goods; and this is to be understood the length of her prayer to Ilukko and his maidens for her kine which were very fair and sleek.

But now Sāri had gone some way, and set his food in his wallet as he drove the kine over the water meadows and swamps and out across the heathland to the rich edge of the woodland, and ever as he went he was grieving and murmuring to himself and saying “Woe to me wretched youth, ill and hard going black fortune: wheresoever I turn my path nothing awaits me but idleness and endless gazing at the tails of oxen ever tramping through the marshes and the dreary level country.” Then coming to a slope in the sun he sat him there and rested and took out his

lunch and marveled at its weight and said, "Wife of Āsemo thou art not wont to dole me out such a weight of food."

Then he fell athinking of his life and the luxury of this spiteful mistress, and to long for wheaten bread in slices thick with butter and cakes of finest baking and for a draught other than water for the quenching of his thirst. Dry crusts, thought he, only does she give me for my chewing and oaten cake at best and with this chaff and straw or the bark of fir not seldom mingled: and cabbage whence her curs has eaten all the fat, and then he bethought him of his wild free early days and of Wanone [*sic*] and his folk, and so slept till a bird prattling of evening awoke him and [he] drove the cattle to rest and sat him on a hillock and took from his back his wallet.

And he opened it and turned it about, saying many a cake without is handsome but within is ill favoured: and is as this wheat above and oaten behind, and being in heavy mood and not over eager for his food he took his great knife wherewith to cut the cake and it shore through the scanty crust and ground with such force on the flint within that its edge was turned and its point snapped: and to this end came Sikki the heirloom of Kampa. And Sāri fell first into white wrath and then into tears for he treasured that heirloom before silver and gold, and said

O my Sikki O my comrade
O thou iron of Kalervo
Which that hero wore and wielded
Nought I had to lose in sorrow
But my knife the picture graver
And against a stone 'tis broken
By the spite of that ill woman.
O my Sikki O my Sikki
O thou iron of Kalervo.

And evil thoughts whispered to him and the fierceness of the wild came into his heart and with his fingers he wove a design of wrath and vengeance against the fair wife of Āsemo: and taking a switch of birch and of juniper from a thicket he drove all the kine and cattle into the water marshes and trackless morasses. And he called in the wolves and bears each to take a half as their prey and to save him only a bone from the leg of Urula the most aged cow of the herd. And from this he made a great pipe and blew shrilly upon it: and this was a magic of Sāri's own nor do men say whence he learnt, and he sang thus the wolves and the cattle and the bears to oxen, and as the sun was westering redly and bending toward the pine-trees nigh the time of milking, he drove the bears and wolves homeward before him, weary and dusty with his weeping on the ground and enchanting of the wild things. Now when he drew

nigh the farmyard he laid his commands upon the beasts that when the smith's wife came to look about her and stooped down to milk them, they should seize her and crunch her in their teeth.

And so he went along the pathway piping broken and strange music from the cow-bone pipe: thrice he blew on the hill slope and six times at the garden wall. And Åsemo's wife marveled whence the neatherd had gotten his cow bone for his pipe but heeded not overmuch the matter, for long had she awaited the cows for milking. And she gave thanks to Ilu for the return of her herd: and went out and bade Sāri stay his earsplitting din and then said she to Åsemo's mother,

Mother 'tis the kine need milking.
Do thou go and tend the cattle
For meseems I cannot finish
Kneading dough as I would have it.

But Sāri mocked her saying that no thrifty housewife would send another and [an] old woman to milk the kine. So Åsemo's wife went swiftly to the sheds and set herself to milk her kine, and gazed upon the herd saying, "Beauteous is the herd to look on and sleek the horned oxen and well filled are the udders of the kine."

Then she stooped to the milking and a wolf sprang at her and a bear seized her in his grim embrace and they tore her fiercely and crunched her bones, and thus was her jesting and mockery and spite repaid, and the cruel wife brought herself to weeping.

And Sāri stood by neither exulting nor relenting and she cried to him, "Ill dost thou most wicked of neatherds to drive bears and mighty wolves to these peaceful yards." Then Sāri chid her for her ill and spite toward himself and for the breaking of his cherished heirloom.

Then Åsemo's wife wheedling said, "Come, thou herdboy, dearest herdboy, come thou apple of this homestead, alter thou thy grim resolve and I beg thee lift this magic from me and release the wolf's jaws and the bear's limbs from me. Better raiment will I give you then an you do so, and handsome ornaments, and wheaten bread and butter and the sweetest draughts of milk for your draining: nor shalt thou labour aught for a year and but lightly in the second."

Then said Sāri, "If thou diest so mayest thou perish; there is room enough in Amuntu for thee."

Then Åsemo's wife in death cursed him using his name and his father's and cried on Ukko the highest of Gods to hear her words.

Woe thou Sāri Kampa's offspring
Woe thou cradled fated child Nyelid
Ill thy fortune dark thy faring

On the roadway of thy lifetime.
Thou hast trod the ways of thralldom
And the trackless waste of exile
But thy end shall be more awful
And a tale to men forever
Of a fate of woe and horror
Worse than anguish in Amuntu.
Men shall hither come from Loke
In the mirklands far to northward
And shall hither come from Same
In the southways of the summer
And shall fare to us from Kēme
And from the ocean bath to westward
But shall shudder when they hear them
To thy fate and end of terror.
Woe thou who as [illegible]

[*The verse breaks off here without closing punctuation or any indication that more is intended. Ed.*]

But Sāri went away and there she died—the daughter of Koi even the fair one whom Āsemo the smith primeval wooed in far Lohiu for seven years. And her cries reached her husband at his forge and he turned from the smithy and went to listen in the lane and then with fear at his heart hastened and looked about the yard and the distant sound of piping shrill and strange faring away out over the marshland under the stars came to his ears and nought else, but to his eyes came soon that evil sight upon the ground and his soul was darkened deeper than the night and starless. But Sāri was far abroad in the wild with pipe of bone and no man might follow for Musti's magic was about him. And his own magic ever waxing went with him too.

And he wandered onwards aimlessly forward for that night and a day through thickest woodland till the next night he found himself in the densest timber grounds of Puhu and it grew stifling dark and he flung himself on the ground and reflected bitterly.

Wherefore have I been created?
Who has made me and has doomed me
Thus 'neath sun and moon to wander
'Neath the open sky forever?
Others to their homes may journey
That stand twinkling in the even
But my home is in the forest.
In the wind halls must I slumber

And in bitter rain must bathe me
And my hearth is midst the heather
in the wide halls of the wind blast
In the rain and in the weather.
Never Jumala most holy
In these ages of the ages
Form a child thus crooked fated
With a friendless doom forever
To go fatherless 'neath heaven
And uncared by any mother
As thou, Jumala, hast made me
Like a wailing wandering seagull,
Like a seamew in the weather
Haunting misty rocks and shoreland
While the sun shines on the swallow
And the sparrow has its brightness
And the birds of air are joyous
But that is never never happy.
I Sāri am not happy.
O Ilu, life is joyless.

{I was small and lost my ~~mother~~ father
I was young (weak) and lost my mother.
All my mighty race has perished
All my mighty race}

Then into his heart Ilu sent a thought, and he lifted his head and said “I will slay Ūlto.” And the thought of his father’s wrong and the tears of his whole lifetime came to him and he said “Gladly will I slay Ūlto.” And as yet was his heart bitter against his own folk too, save Wānōna only, and he thought him fiercely of the red light leaping from Untamo’s dwellings and Untamo lying dead on the stained floor of his own grim halls. But Kullervo knew not his way thence for on every side the forest encompassed him; still he fared onward saying “Wait thou Untamoinen destroyer of my race; if I find thee then quickly wilt thy dwelling leap up in flames and the farmlands lie empty and withered.”

As he fared musing an old dame, even the Blue-robed Lady of the Forest met him asking him “Whither O Kullervo son of Kalervo goest thou so hastily?”

Then Kullervo told her of his desire to quit the forest and wander to the homestead of Untamo and with fire avenge his father’s death and his mother’s tears.

Then said she, “Easy it is for thee to journey though the track be not known to thee through the forest. Thou must follow the river’s path and

march for two days and a third day when turning to the northwest thou wilt find a wooded mountain. Fare not towards it lest ill find thee. March on under the shadow often bending to the left when thou comest to another river and when thou hast followed its banks soon thou wilt strike a fair spot and a great glade and over a great leap a triple waterfall foaming. Then you will know that thou art halfway. Even so thou must continue pushing up the river towards its source: and the ground will slope against thee and the wood darken and lie in again till for a day you stumble cross a bleak waste and then soon wilt thou see the blue of woods of Untamo rising afar off: and mayhap these thou hast not yet quite forgotten."

Then slipped the Woman of the Forest away among the tree boles and Kullervo following the river—for one not very great was nigh—marched for two days and a third day, then turned to Northwest and espied the wooded mountain and the sun shone upon it and the trees bloomed and the bees seemed a-humming there and the birds singing, and Kullervo tired of the blue shadows of the woods and thought—my quest will wait, for never can Untamo in the end escape me: I will go drink the sunlight. And he turned from the forest path into the sun; and was going up the slopes till he came to a wide clearing and on a fallen log in a patch of light amidst the brambles he saw a maiden with her yellow hair all flowing. And the curse of Louhi's daughter was on him and his eyes saw and saw not: and he forgot the slaying of Untamo and strode to the maiden who heeded him not. A garland of flowers was she plaiting and was singing yet wearily and half sorrowfully to herself.

"O fair one, pride of Earth," said Kullervo, "come with me; wander in the forest with me unless indeed thou be a daughter of Tapio and no human maiden: but even so I do desire thee to be my comrade."

And the maid was affright and shrank from him. "Death walketh with thee, wanderer, and woe is at thy side."

And Kullervo was wroth; but very fair was the maiden and he said "Tis not good for thee to be alone in the forest; nor does it please me; food will I bring thee and fare abroad to lay and lie in wait for thee, and gold and raiment and many things of cost wilt give thee."

"Though I be lost in the evil woods, and Tapio has me fast in his hold," said she, "yet would I never wish to roam with such as thee, villain. Little does thy look consort with maidens. But thou wouldst, an thou were honest aid me to find the homeward road to my folk which Tapio hides from me."

But Kullervo was wroth in that she had reviled his ungainliness, and put kind thought from him and cried, "Lempo seize thy folk and swift would I put them to the sword didst I come upon them, but thou I wilt have nor shalt thou dwell in thy father's house again."

Whereat she was adread and sped like a wild thing of the woods

through the tangle from him and he angrily after her till he laid hands upon her and bore her in his arms away in the depths of the woods.

Yet was she fair and he loving with her, and the curse of the wife of Ilmarinen upon them both, so that not long did she resist him and they abode together in the wild till on a day even as Jumala brought the morning, the damsel resting in his arms spake unto him questioning him and said,

Tell me now of all thy kinfolk
Of the brave race that thou springst from:—
Yea, a mighty race it seems me
Thine is, and a mighty father.

And Kullervo’s answer was thus:

[*These lines are offset apparently to indicate a change in speaker—Ed.*]

Nay, my race is not a great one,
Not a great one nor a small one:
I am just of middle station;
Kallervo’s unhappy offspring
Uncouth boy and ever foolish
Worthless child and good for nothing.
Nay but tell me of thy people
Of the brave race whence thou comest.
Maybe a mighty race has born thee
Fairest child of mighty father.

And the girl answered quickly (nor let Kullervo see her face),

Nay my race is not a great one
Not a great one nor a small one
I am just of middle station
Wandering maiden ever foolish
Worthless child and good for nothing.

Then stood she up and gazing in woe at Kullervo with outstretched hand and her hair falling about her cried,

To the wood I went for berries
And forsook my tender mother.
Over plains and heaths and mountains
Wandered two days and a third one
Till the pathway home I found not.
For the paths led ever deeper
Deeper deeper into darkness
Deeper deeper into sorrow

Into woe and into horror.
O thou sunlight O thou moonbeam
O thou dear unfettered breezes
Never never will I see thee
Never feel thee on my forehead.
For I go in dark and terror
Down to Tuoni to the River.

And before he could leap up and grasp her she sped across the glade (for they abode in a wild dwelling nigh to the glade spoken to him by the Blue Forest Woman) like a shivering ray in the dawn light scarce seeming to touch the green dewy grass till she came to the triple fall and cast her over it down its silver column to the ugly depths even as Kullervo came up with her and her last wail he heard and stood heavy bent on the brink as a lump of rock till the sun rose and thereat the grass grew green and the birds sang and the flowers opened and midday passed and all things seemed happy: and Kullervo cursed them, for he loved her.

And the light waned and foreboding gnawed at his heart for something in the maiden's last speech and manner and her bitter ending awakened old knowledge in his heart spell-blind and he felt he would burst for grief and sorrow and heavy fear. Then red anger came to him and he cursed and seized his sword and [went] blindly in the dark heeding neither falls nor bruises up the river as the Dame had directed, panting as the slopes leant against him till at dawn so terrible his haste

[The narrative breaks off at this point, and what follows on the rest of the page is a note-outline of the end of the story, written rapidly and with aberrations in syntax attributable to haste. It is here given in full. Ed.]

He goes to Untola and blindly lays waste to everything, gathering an army of bears and wolves together who vanish in the evening and slay the following Musti outside the vill[age]. When everything is destroyed, he flings himself drenched in blood on the bed of Untamo, his self the only house not burnt.

His mother's ghost appears to him and tells him his own brother and sister are amongst those he has slain.

He is horror struck but not grieved.

She then tells him that she was too and he starts up in a sweat and horror believing he is dreaming and is prostrated when he finds it not so.

Then she goes on.

(~~He had a daughter~~ ^{He had a daughter} fairest maiden who wandered to look for berries)

Telling how she met a fair distraught maiden wandering with

downcast eyes by the bank of Tuoni’s river and describes their meeting ending by revealing that it is she who slew herself.

Kullervo bites sword hilt in anguish and starts up wildly as his mother vanishes. Then he laments her and goes out setting fire to the hall, passing through the village full of slain into the woods wailing “Kivutar” for he has never seen her (or his sister) since he was sold to Ilmarinen. He finds the glade now bleak and desolate [*in the margin is the note: falls over body of dead Musti*] and is about to throw himself over same falls when he decides he is not fit to drown in same pools as Kivutar and takes out his sword asking it whether it will slay him.

The sword says if it had joy in the death of Untamo how much in death of even wickeder Kullervoinen. And it had slaid [sic] many an innocent person, even his mother, so it would not boggle over Kullervo.

He kills himself and finds the death he sought for.

MS FOLIO 6—LIST OF NAMES

[*The spacing here is as it appears in the manuscript, Ed.*]

[Recto]

Tuva	Niel	
Tuva (w Nyēli)	Uto	
Kampa (Nēyli)	Ūto Kem	
or Kēma	(Puhōsa his land)	
Sāari	Wanōna	
or honto		
Black dog	<u>Mauri</u>	
Smith	Āsemo	
cf	Āse	
Lumya	the Marshland	
Teleā	land of Kēme's birth	
Kēmēnūme	or the Great Land	
Ilu Iluko	God of the Sky	
	(the good God)	
often confused with Ukko	∴ ran	
Amuntu	hell	
Tanto	Goddess of hell	Pūh
Lempi	plague & death	
also called Qēle or as a [illegible] name	Kuruwanyo	
The great black river of death	Kūru	
Ilwe	Ilwinti Sky heaven	(Manatomi)
Wanwe	armed goddess	
Sutse the	marshland	
Samyan	god of the forest	
Koi Queen of [illegible]	Lōke	

[Verso]

the seven daughters of Ilwinti	
	Eltelen Mēlune
and Salkuire	
Tekkitai	
Malōlō a god	the maker
of the earth	
Kaltūse or	

DRAFT PLOT SYNOPSES, FOLIO 21.

A loose folio numbered 21 contains on both sides jotted notes and rough plot outlines alternative to the continuous narrative. The use of the names Ilmarinen and Louhi is evidence that this precedes the main manuscript.

[MS folio 21 recto]

Kalervo and his wife and son daughter

~~Kullervo a boy child with his father Kalervo~~

The quarrel and raid of Untamo

The homestead laid waste — Kalervo slain ~~and as Kullervo in anguish~~ & all his folk and his wife is carried off by Untamo

She bears Kullervo and a younger sister in sorrow & anguish and tells them of the Tale of Kalervo.

~~Untamo~~ Kull. waxed to marvellous strength: his vow as an infant: the knife (his passionate resentful nature) his ill treatment by Untamo

His only friend his sister: his misbehaviour and selling in slavery to Ilmarinen

His solitary misery: how he speaks with wolves in the mountain. carving strange figures with his father's knife

The cake of Louhi's daughter: Rage and revenge of Kullervo: refuses to loose spell & is cursed by Ilmarinen's dying wife.

He flees from Ilmarinen and vows the destroying of Untamo: returning from his triumph he meets a maiden and forces her to dwell with him: he reveals his name and she turns wailing into the dark and flings herself over the savage falls.

Kullervo standing in sorrow beside the falls

[Verso]

Dog Musti

Quarrelsome mean Kalervo Kind mother wretched elder sister & brother

falls in with the Pohie-Lady of the Forest Who tells him where his mother is dwelling (give description) with his brother and daughters. And he leaves his sorrow and rides to the homestead. [*begin cancel*] The meeting with his mother: he

recounts and she recounts their var[ious] lives since her slavery [*end cancel*]. He finds his mother wailing, she has sought her younger and dearly loved daughter for three years in the woods and describes her. Kullervo sees what has happ to his sister and rides recklessly over the ways to the

falls where he slays himself.

Or he can meet the maiden in the woodland while fleeing from Ilmarinen and to quench his sorrow [*in margin* alay his suspicion aroused by his sister's death] go and devastate Untamo and rescue his mother from bondage discover it is his sister and ride back red with the blood of Untamo and slay himself at the Falls.

put the speech of ~~Unt~~ Kull R. 36/40 [illegible] met Kull encounter when his mother beseeches him to be more obedient to Untamo as a boy. (Mother and Brother are glad he's to go. Sister alone sorry)

Or make it thus after flight from Ilma he finds his people— then destroys untamo gathering an [sic] magic army of his old friends the wolves and bears: Untamo ~~curse~~s enchants him and he wanders blinded through the forest. Comes to a village and sacks it slaying the ancient headman and his wife and taking as wife by force his daughter.

Who asking him his lineage he reveals
she reveals his origin and how he has slain
both father and mother and despoiled his sister

Lament of Honto 34/240

NOTES AND COMMENTARY

The Story of Honto Taltewenlen. An alternate title or sub-title written in the upper left corner of the folio, apparently a late addition. *Honto* is one of Tolkien's several by-names for Kullervo (see below); *Talte* is his by-name for Kalervo (see below); *wenlen*, a patronymic suffix equivalent to *poika*, is apparently a Tolkien invention based on the Finnish model. *Taltewenlen* would thus be "Son of Talte (Kalervo)."

(Kalervonpoika). *Poika* is a Finnish patronymic suffix, thus the full name means "Kalervo's Son," or "Son of Kalervo."

Sutse. A name of Tolkien's invention intended to replace earlier "Suomi" (the Finnish name for Finland) in the text. Other replacement names, all written in the left margin of this opening paragraph, include "Telea" for earlier Karelja, "the Great Land/ Kemenūme" for earlier Russia, and "Talte" (see above) for earlier Kalervo. Asterisks beside both textual and marginal names coordinate the emendations. With the exception of "Talte," the replacement names become standard, and are more or less consistently used throughout the remainder of the text. These changes offer the clearest evidence of Tolkien's developing tendency to go from merely following the *Kalevala* nomenclature to using names of his own invention.*

*A circumstance worth noting is that *Kemenūme* appears in very early notes on Quenya as a name for Russia. See also *Ilu* below.

when magic was yet new. This phrase, cancelled in the manuscript, is here retained in brackets, since magic (also called sorcery) is practiced throughout the story by Untamo, who is described as “a fell sorcerer and man of power,” by the dog Musti (himself a possessor of magic abilities), and by Kullervo, who can shape-change animals. *Kalevala* has numerous references to magic, probably remnants of primitive shamanism and shamanic practices usually performed through singing. One of the “big three” heroes of *Kalevala*, Väinämöinen, has been interpreted as a shaman. He has the epithet “eternal singer,” and defeats a rival magician in a singing contest by singing him into a bog. In Tolkien’s story both Untamo and Kullervo “weave” magic with their fingers. Kullervo also uses music—singing and playing a magic cow-bone-pipe.

Telea. Replaces earlier Karelja. Karelja is a large area on both sides of the Russo-Finnish border, and is the region where most of the narrative *runos* (songs) used in compiling *Kalevala* were collected.

The Great Land (Kemenūme). Replaces Russia in the text. May be based on *Kemi*, a river in northern Finland on which stands the town of the same name. But see note in entry for *Sutse* above.

Kalervo Father of Kullervo, his name is probably a variant of Kaleva, a Finnish culture-hero and patronymic ancestor whose name survives in *Kalevala* (with locative suffix *-la*, “place or habitation” thus Land of Heroes), and in that of his descendent Kalervo. Kalervo is also called by Tolkien *Tälte*, *Tältelouhi*, *Kampa*, and *Kalervoinen*, the last formed with the Finnish diminutive suffix *inen*. In Finnish, a name can occur in several different forms, depending on the use of diminutives. Cp Untamoinen below.

Untamo. Also called *Untamoinen*, *Unti*, *Ūlto*, *Ulko*, *Ulkho*.

black hound Musti. Tolkien first called the dog Musti, a conventional Finnish dog name based on *musta*, “black,” translating as something like “Blackie.” Halfway through the draft, he changed the name to Mauri—possibly formed on Finnish Muuri/Muurikki, “Black one” or “Blackie,” (used of a cow)—then reverted to Musti. I have retained Musti throughout.

cruel and worthless carles. *Carl*: a churl, a rustic, a peasant. Compare Anglo-Saxon *ceorl*. Tolkien’s text mixes Anglo-Saxon archaism with Finnish and pseudo-Finnish names.

borne in years past both a son and a daughter and was even now again nigh to childbirth. The elder brother and sister of Kullervo appear in *Kalevala* but only enter the story after Kullervo escapes the smith. This ignores the fact that Untamo has already destroyed everyone but Kalervo's wife, who is pregnant and delivers Kullervo in captivity. The compiler of *Kalevala*, Elias Lönnrot, apparently combined two separate stories in order to include Kullervo's incest and death. Tolkien repairs the disjuncture by introducing the older brother and sister at the beginning of the story.

fouly entreated his folk and lands. The word "entreat," which conventionally has the meaning of "supplicate" or "plead with," seems startlingly inapposite in this context. It is not a mistake, however, but Tolkien's deliberate usage of the word in its archaic meaning as cited in the Oxford English Dictionary, of "treated" or "dealt with." The O.E.D. gives an example from 1430; "So betyn (beaten), so woundyd, Entretyd so fuly [fouly]."

gloomy halls of Untola. The locative or habitative suffix *la* identifies this as the home of Unto (Untamo).

Kalervo's babes. In *Kalevala* Kullervo discovers late in the story, after escaping the smith, that he has a sister, but the twinning of the siblings in the present narrative is the invention of Tolkien and not in the original.

Kullervo. Tolkien translates the name as "wrath," a meaning unattested in *Kalevala*, said to be of disputed origin. It appears to be formed off the patronymic Kalervo. Tolkien described his hero as "hapless Kullervo," and identified him as "the germ of my attempt to write legends of my own" (*Letters* 345). Kullervo is the earliest of Tolkien's displaced, heroes, orphans and exiles, a succession that will include Túrin (modeled directly on Kullervo), Beren, and Frodo. Tolkien gives his Kullervo a variety of by-names or epithets: *Kuli* (an obvious short form of Kullervo), *Sake*, *Sakehonto*, *Honto*, *Säri*, *Sarihonto*. Such multiple naming is typical of *Kalevala*, where for example the hero Lemmenkainen, has the nicknames *Ahti* (King of the Waves"), *Ahti-Saarelainen* ("Island-Ahti" or "Man of the Island"), *Kaukomieli* ("[Handsome] man with a far-roving mind"), *Kaukolainen* ("Man of Faraway Farm").

Wanōna, or "weeping." Compare Túrin Turambar's surviving sister, Nienor/ Niniel, whose names mean respectively "mourning" and "tear-maiden." Wanōna is a name of Tolkien's own devising, as in *Kalevala* the sister is not named. One early occurrence in the manuscript calls her Welinore, but this is immediately crossed out and replaced with Wanōna. One instance late in the manuscript changes Wanōna to "Wanora," but

it only appears once, and I have retained “Wanōna” throughout. In *Kalevala*, Kullervo and his sister meet as strangers.

for ill cradle rocking. The “for” in this phrase should be taken to mean “because of.” The tradition that physical mistreatment of an infant could have psychological repercussions is an old one. Compare the saying, “as the twig is bent so grows the tree.”

one generation from the men of magic. Compare with Tolkien’s use of the word *magic* in the opening line, “when magic was yet new.” Kullervo is in touch with ancient shamanic practices.

not yet more than knee-high. Mythic heroes traditionally grow at an accelerated rate. Compare the Greek Hercules and the Irish Cú Chulainn. Wanōna, described as “wondrous,” also grows at an accelerated rate. In this respect, the twins may owe something to the classical Apollo and Artemis, twin children of Leto by Zeus. In some versions of their story both grew to full adulthood within the day of their birth.

hound of Tuoni. Hounds in mythology are frequently associated with the underworld, either as guardians or as guides. Tuoni is Death (personified) also called Lord of Death. His domain is Tuonela, the underworld, so-called from his name plus the locative/habitative suffix *la*.

Tuoni the marshland. Perhaps an error for Suomi, See entry for “Sutse” above.

[and to Kullervo he gave three hairs . . .] This entire sentence, cancelled in the manuscript, is retained in the present text since a magic hair of Musti later saves Kullervo’s life.

the great knife Sikki. In *Kalevala* the knife is not named.

Now in sooth a man I deem me. This is the first of the “chunks of poetry” interspersing the prose sections which Tolkien described (*Letters* 7) as his narrative style for “The Story of Kullervo.” It is in the so-called “*Kalevala* meter” that Tolkien would have known from the Kirby translation in which he first read *Kalevala*. This is a rendering into English of the Finnish four-beat eight-syllable line, and is most familiar to English-speakers as the meter of Longfellow’s *Hiawatha*. It is less monotonous in Finnish.

Lempo. Described in Folio 6 as “plague and desolation.” The name is confusingly close to the *Kalevala* name for *Lempi*, father of the playboy hero Lemminkäinen. Finnish *lempi* is “erotic love.” Tolkien has borrowed the name but not the meaning.

daughter of Keime. Obscure. Possibly a reference to Russia, called *Kemenūme* in the text; alternatively a possible reference to *Teleä/Karelja*, glossed in Folio 6 as “land of Kēme’s birth.”

Āsemo the smith. The name *Āsemo* is apparently Tolkien’s invention to replace the *Kalevala*’s name for this character, *Ilmarinen*, formed on *ilma*, “sky, air”. *Āsemo* may be formed from Finnish *ase*, “weapon, tool” (he is, after all, a smith) with the suffix *mo*, used to change a noun into a proper name. In *Kalevala* the smith has a far greater role, hammering out the lid of the sky and forging the magical Sampo, actions which qualify him as a kind of creator-god, but might have made him too potent a figure for his minor role in Tolkien’s story. Mythic heroes such as Kullervo are often fostered out to smiths; for example the Irish Setanta was fostered to the smith Culann from whom he took the name by which he was thenceforth known, Cū Chulainn, “Hound of Culann.” The Norse hero Sigurd was mentored by the smith Regin. Puhōsa, the smith’s homestead is hard to locate geographically. It is said at various times to be in the Great Lands identified in the opening paragraphs as Russia, but also in *Telea*, identified with *Karelja*.

swart and illfavoured. It is Tolkien’s invention to have his hero’s angry and resentful internal emotional state externalized in his dark and ugly outward appearance. In *Kalevala*, Kullervo is described as handsome and yellow-haired.

thralldom. Slavery, serfdom, state of bondage. From Anglo-Saxon *thrael*, from Old Norse *thræll*, “servant.”

daughter of Koi Queen of the Marshlands. The smith’s wife, in *Kalevala* called *Pohjan neiti*, “North maid, North miss,” is unnamed in Tolkien’s story, identified only as the daughter of Koi. In Finnish *koi* is not a proper name but a word meaning “dawn, daybreak,” so this usage is Tolkien’s invention. Although Koi does not appear in the story, Tolkien describes her in a name-list as “Queen of Lōke” (see below). Tolkien clearly means the character to be equivalent to Louhi, a major character in *Kalevala*, where she is a sorceress, the Mistress of Pohjola the Land of the North, and the scheming mother of the North Maid. The name *Louhi* is a shortened form of *Loviatar*, minus the feminine suffix *tar*. In *Kalevala*, Loviatar is called Death’s daughter, the half-blind daughter of Death’s Domain. One of Tolkien’s name-lists identifies “Louhiatar” as “name of smith’s wife” (see entry for *Kiwutar* below).

Puhōsa. Untamo’s homestead. Also called Puhu, perhaps as a diminutive.

blue woods/Blue Forest. Finnish *sininen salo* translates literally as “blue wilderness,” but is often translated “hazy blue wilderness” or “blue woodland haze,” the result of rising mist in forested areas and especially in low-lying ground. Tolkien associates the color and the phenomenon with mystery and magic—blue Puhōsa, the blue woods round Untamo’s dwelling, the Blue Forest of Kullervo’s wanderings.

Ukko. The ancient Finnish thunder-god. The name means “old man”, and the diminutive, *ukkonen*, is a term for thunder. See “Ilú” below.

Ilú the God of Heaven. Also called Iluko and sometimes confused with Ukko. In Tolkien’s list of names in Folio 6 (see below) Ilú is identified as the God of the Sky. Contrast with Malōlō below. It is worth noting that *Ilú* is also the initial element in *Ilúvatar*, the Elvish name for the godhead of Tolkien’s mythology, the Silmarillion.

Manatomi. Sky, heaven, also called Ilwe, Ilwinti.

Guard my kine. The longest of Tolkien’s “chunks of poetry,” this charm to protect cattle follows closely the incantation of equivalent length by the smith’s wife in Runo 32 of the “Kullervo” portion of *Kalevala*, which Tolkien calls the “splendid kine-song” (see essay and Notes). He clearly felt it to be an important element in both *Kalevala* and his own story. Both passages are testament to the importance of animal husbandry in a subsistence economy, and both, by their naming of the many woodland and nature spirits (though here Tolkien allows himself some poetic invention) give a good picture of the pagan Finnish worldview.

daughters of Malōlō. Folio 6 identifies Malōlō as “a god, the maker of the earth.” In the preceding lines the daughters are called “maidens great and ancient,” and “mighty daughters of the Heaven.” They appear to be ancient feminine divinities or spirits.

daughters of Ilwinti. Apparently air spirits, perhaps breezes. *Ilwinti* is formed from *ilma*, “sky, air.” The mother goddess in *Kalevala* is called *Ilmatar*, “Maid of the Air” (Magoun), or “Daughter of the Air” (Kirby); literally “air maiden” from *ilma* (“air”) plus *tar*, the feminine suffix.

Manoine. From its context with “daughters of Ilwinti,” “blue meads of Ilwinti,” and “white kine” (clouds), Manoine is likely to be equivalent to Manatomi as sky or heaven (see Manatomi above).

Palikki’s little damsel, Telenda, Kaltuse, Pulu, Kūru (see entry for **Kūru** below), **Sampia.** Names of Tolkien’s invention.

Kame. Perhaps a variant of Kēme.

Terenye maid of Samyan. Folio 6 lists Samyan as “god of the forest,” making him the equivalent of (or replacement for) Tapio, whose daughter is Tellervo, also called “wind spirit”. Terenye could then be either a forest spirit, a dryad, or akin to the daughters of Ilwinti.

And the women fire will kindle. On Finnish farms smudge fires were lit in the evenings, creating smoke to keep away mosquitoes which bothered the cattle.

Honeypaw. Certain wild animals in Northern Europe, such as the bear and the wolf, were considered so powerful that to speak their names was to invite their appearance, with predictable danger to human life. Thus by-names or descriptions were often used such as “honeypaw,” or “bru-in” or “winter sleeper,” or “woodland apple” for the bear. All of these appellations are applied to bears in *Kalevala*, where the actual word for “bear” is *karhu*. In Tolkien’s poem the smith’s wife calls the bear “Uru” (bear) but she also flatters him with an affectionate-sounding nickname.

neatherd. An old word for cattleherder. The word *neat* is archaic and obsolete, but is specific in distinguishing cattle (cows) and oxen from other domestic hoofed animals such as sheep or goats.

Kūru. In Folio 6 called “The great black river of death” with possible variant Kuruwanyo. Finnish *kuolema* is “death,” and Tolkien may have formed the name from that base.

Amuntu. In Folio 6 identified as Hell.

Nyelid. The list of names on Folio 6 gives Nyēli as a by-name for Kam-pa, which is itself a by-name for Kalervo. *Nyelid* could mean something like “of the clan of.”

far Lohiu. Etymologically similar to “Louhi” and “Louhiatar” but here clearly referring to a place, not a personage. See entry for Lōke below.

Jumala most holy. In *Kalevala*, Jumala is a sacred being, often translated as “God,” “God on high,” or “Creator.” Perhaps originally a pagan figure but assimilated to Christianity.

Men shall hither come from Lōke. A place-name apparently equivalent to Lohiu. The similarity to Loki, the name of the Old Norse trickster god, may be intentional. An etymological relationship between Loki and Louhi has been suggested, but cannot be demonstrated.

I was small and lost my mother father

I was young (weak) and lost my mother. Cancelled in the manuscript, the lines are a near direct quote from Kirby’s translation of *Kal-*

evala: “I was small and lost my father, I was weak and lost my mother.” They are retained here as a possible indication of Tolkien’s interest in what he called “a very great story and most tragic.” The parallel with Tolkien’s own life—his father died when he four years old, his mother when he was twelve—is self-evident.

Blue-robed Lady of the Forest/ Blue Forest Woman/Woman of the Forest. The first title follows that of Kirby’s translation, and Tolkien has added variations on the epithet. Magoun’s translation has “green-robed maid of the thicket,” Friburg’s has “blue-robed matron of the forest.” The mistress of the forest, traditionally named as *Mielikki*, is the consort or wife of *Tapio*, a major woodland deity. The world of *Kalevala* is full of nature spirits, woodland demi-gods who appear when needed. This one has a particularly portentous role, since it is when *Kullervo* disobeys her instructions to avoid the mountain that he has the fated meeting with his sister.

Louhi’s daughter. Almost certainly an error for “*Koi*’s daughter,” the smith’s wife.

daughter of *Tapio*. A dryad, a woodland spirit.

the wife of *Ilmarinen*. A mistake for *Åsemo*. *Ilmarinen* is the smith in *Kalevala* and Tolkien originally kept the name, then changed it to *Åsemo* (see above).

wailing “*Kivutar*” Although she is unnamed in *Kalevala* and Tolkien’s text, *Kullervo*’s sister apparently was at one stage of composition to have had the name *Kivutar*. At the bottom of a page of notes which also has a fair-copy draft of “Now in sooth” is written a brief list of names:

Kalervo >	Paiväta
Kiputyttö	maiden of pain his wife;
Kivultar	daughter of pain his daughter.
Louhiatar	name of Smith’s wife
Saari	Kalervoinen the hero

Both *Kiputyttö* and *Kivultar* are formed from Finnish *kipu*, “pain.” In their translations of *Kalevala* Friburg calls *Kiputyttö* “ [sic] “Pain Maiden”; Magoun calls her “Pain Girl” and translates *Kivutar* as “Pain Spirit” and identical with “Pain Girl” (i.e. “maiden of pain.”). Kirby leaves the names untranslated.

On "The Kalevala" or Land of Heroes

[*Manuscript draft*]

I

I am afraid this paper was not originally written for this society, which I hope it will pardon since I produce it mainly to form a stop-gap tonight, to entertain you as far as possible in spite of the sudden collapse of the intended reader.

I hope the society will also forgive besides its second-hand character its quality: which is hardly that of a paper—rather a disconnected soliloquy accompanied by a leisurely patting on the back of a pet volume. If I continually drop into talking of these poems as if no one in the room had read these poems before, it is because no one had, when I first read it; and you must also attribute it to the pet attitude. I am very fond of these poems—they are literature so very unlike any of the things that are familiar to general readers, or even to those versed in the more curious by-paths: they are so un-European and yet could only come from Europe.

Any one who has read this collection of ballads (more especially in the original which is vastly different to any translation) will I think agree to that. Most people are familiar from the age of their earliest books onward with the general mould and type of mythological stories, legends, Romances, that come to us from many sources: from Hellas by many channels, from the Celtic peoples, Irish and British, and from the Teutonic (I put these in order of increasing appeal to myself); and which achieve forums[?], with their crowning glory in Stead's Books for the Bairns—that mine of ancient lore. They have a certain style, or savour; a something akin to one another in spite of their vast cleavages that make you feel that whatever the difference of ultimate race of those speakers there is something kindred in the imagination of the speakers of Indo-European languages.

Trickles come in from a vague and alien East of course (it is even reflected in the above beloved pink covers) but alien influence, if felt, is more on the final literary shapes than on the fundamental stories. Then perhaps you discover the Kalevala, (or to translate it roughly: it is so much easier to say) the Land of Heroes; and you are at once in a new world; and can revel in an amazing new excitement. You feel like Columbus on a new Continent or Thorfinn in Vinland the good. When you first step onto the new land you can if you like immediately begin comparing it with the one you have come from. Mountains, rivers, grass, and so on are probably common features to both. Some plants and animals may seem familiar especially the wild and ferocious human species; but it is more likely to be the often almost indefinable sense of newness and strangeness that will either perturb you or delight you. Trees will

group differently on the horizon, the birds will make unfamiliar music; the inhabitants will talk a wild and at first unintelligible lingo. At the worst I hope however that after this the country and its manners have become more familiar and you have got on speaking terms with the natives you will find it rather jolly to live with this strange people and these new gods awhile, with this race of unhypocritical scandalous heroes and sadly unsentimental lovers: and at the last you may feel you do not want to go back home for a long while if at all.

This is how it was for me when I first read the Kalevala—that is, crossed the gulf between the Indo-European-speaking peoples of Europe into this smaller realm of those who cling in queer corners to the forgotten tongues and manners of an elder day. The newness worried me, sticking in awkward lumps through the clumsiness of a translation which had not at all overcome its peculiar difficulties; it irritated and yet attracted: and each time you read it the more you felt at home and enjoyed yourself. When Honour Mods should have been occupying all my forces I once made a wild assault on the stronghold of the original language and was repulsed at first with heavy losses: but it is easy almost to see the reason why the translations are not at all good; it is that we are dealing with a language separated by a quite immeasurable gulf in method and expression from English. There is however a possible third case which I have not considered: you may be merely antagonistic and desire to catch the next boat back to your familiar country. In that case before you go, which had best be soon, I think it only fair to say that if you feel that heroes of the Kalevala do behave with a singular lack of conventional dignity and with a readiness for tears and dirty dealing, they are no more undignified and not nearly so difficult to get on with as a medieval lover who takes to his bed to weep for the cruelty of his lady in that she will not have pity on him and condemns him to a melting death; but who is struck with the novelty of the idea when his kindly adviser points out that the poor lady is as yet uninformed in any way of his attachment. The lovers of the Kalevala are forward and take a deal of rebuffing. There is no Troilus to need a Pandarus to do his shy wooing for him: rather here it is the mothers-in-law who do some sound bargaining behind the scenes and give cynical advice to their daughters calculated to shatter the most stout illusions.

One repeatedly hears the "Land of Heroes" described as the "national Finnish Epic": as if a nation besides if possible a national bank, theatre, and government ought also automatically to possess a national epic. Finland does not. The Kalevala is certainly not one. It is a mass of conceivably epic material: but, and I think this is the main point, it would lose nearly all that which is its greatest delight if it were ever to be epically handled. The mere stories, the bare events, alone could remain;

all that underworld, all that rich profusion and luxuriance which clothe them would be stripped away. The "Land of Heroes" is in fact a collection of that delightful absorbing material which, on the appearance of an epic artist, because of its comparative lowness of emotional pitch, has elsewhere inevitably been cast aside, and afterwards overshadowed (far too often) has vanished into disuse and utter oblivion.

It is any case to all that body of myths of queer troglodyte story, of wild jugglings with the sun and moon and the origins of the earth and the shapes of Man that in Homer (for instance) has properly been pruned away; it is to this that the *Kalevala* may be compared, not to the larger grandeur of the epic theme. Or again it is to the quaint tales, the outrageous ghosts, the sorceries and by-tracks of human imagination and belief that crop out here and there in the usually intensely clear air of the sagas that the "Land of Heroes" can be likened, not to the haughty dignity and courage, the nobility of which the grislier sagas tell. But the queer and strange, the unrestrained, the grotesque is not only interesting, it is valuable. It is not always necessary to purge it out altogether in order to attain to the Sublime. You can have your gargoyles on your noble cathedral, but Europe has lost much through too often trying to build Greek Temples.

We have here then a collection of mythological ballads full of that very primitive undergrowth that the litterature of Europe has on the whole been cutting away and reducing for centuries with different and earlier completeness in different peoples. Such a collection would no doubt be the despoil of anthropologists who might luxuriate here awhile. Commentators I know make many notes to their translations, saying "Compare this story with the one told in the Andaman Isles" or "Compare that belief with the one shown in the Hausa Folktales" and so forth—but let us avoid this. It after all only proves that Finns and Andaman Islanders are nearly related animals (which we knew before). Let us rather rejoice that we have come suddenly upon a storehouse of those popular imaginings which we had feared lost, stocked with stories as yet not sophisticated into a sense of proportion; with no thought of the decent limits even of exaggeration, with no sense, or rather not our sense, of the incongruous (except where we suspect incongruity is delighted in). We are taking a holiday from the whole course of progress of the last three Milleniums; and going to be wildly unhellenic and barbarous for a time, like the boy who hoped the future life would provide for half holidays in Hell, away from Eton collars and hymns.

The glorious exaggerations of these ballads, by way of illustration, recall the method of story telling in the *Mabinogion*, but really their cases are rather different. In the *Kalevala* there is no attempt at plausibility, no cunning concealment of the impossible; merely the child's delight

in saying how he has cut down a million trees and slaughtered twenty policemen: which has no thought to take you in but is a primitive hero-story. Of course in the Mabinogion there is the same delight in a good story, in a strange swap of imagination but the picture has more technique. Its colours are marvellously schemed, its figures grouped. It is not so with Land of Heroes. If a man kills a gigantic elk in one line it may be a she-bear in the next. To elaborate this is unnecessary: but it might be made the occasion of an attempt to say just what I find the atmosphere of the Kalevala to be: which you can correct from your own knowledge, or from the extracts which I would wish to read until your patience was exhausted and you felt the appropriateness of the last remarks of the Kalevala.

“Een the waterfall when flowing
yields no endless stream of water.
Nor does an accomplished singer
sing till all his knowledge fails him.”

What I feel is—that there is no background of literary tradition. The Mabinogion has such a background: a feeling of a great amount of development which has resulted in a field of the most excellently harmonised and subtly varied colours against which the figures of the actors of the stories stand out; but they also harmonize with the marvellous surrounding colour-scheme and lose in startlingness if not in clearness. Most similar national legend literature has something of it. The Kalevala to me feels to have none. The colours, the deeds, the marvels, and the figures of the heroes are all splashed onto a clean bare canvas by a sudden hand: even the legends concerning the origins of the most ancient things seem to come fresh from the singer’s hot imagination of the moment. There are no ultra modernities like trams or guns or aeroplanes in it: the heroes’ weapons it is true are the so-called “antique” bow and spear and sword but at the same time there is a “nowness”, a quite unhazy unromantic momentariness and presentness that quite startles you, especially when you discover that you are reading all the time of the Earth being made out of a teal’s egg or the sun and moon being shut up in a mountain.

II

As to what is known of the origin of the Kalevala: ever since the coming of Väinämöinen and his making of the great harp, the Kantele fashioned of pike-bone, from what we know of the Finns they have always been fond of ballads; and those ballads have been handed on and sung day after day with unending zest from father to son and son to grandson down to the present day when, as the ballads now bewail, “The songs are songs of bygone ages/ hidden words of ancient wisdom/, songs which all

the children sing not/ all beyond men's comprehension/ in these ages of
unfortune/ when the race is near the ending." The Shadow of Sweden
and then of Russia has been over the country for many centuries. Petro-
grad is in Finland. But the remarkable and delightful thing is that these
"songs of bygone ages" have not been tinkered with.

Sweden finally in [the] twelfth century conquered Finland (after con-
tinual warfare combined with some intercourse that stretches back beyond
the beginning of our era in which too our own ancestors in Holstein had
a good part). Christianity then began slowly to be introduced—in other
words the Finns were one of the last acknowledged pagan people in Me-
dieval Europe. The *Kalevala* today is practically untouched: and except
at the end and in a few references to Ukko God of Heaven even hints
at the existence of Christianity are almost entirely absent. This largely
accounts for its interest and "undergrowth" character, though also for its
minor emotional key: its narrow and parochial view (things in themselves
not without delight).

For another seven centuries the ballads were handed on in spite of
Sweden, in spite of Russia and were not written down until Elias Lönnrot
in 1835 made a selection of them. These were all collected in Eastern
Finland and are consequently in a dialect different to that of modern
literary Finnish. This dialect has become a kind of poetic convention.
Lönnrot was not the only collector, but it was to him that it occurred to
string a selection into loosely connected form—as it would seem from
the result with no small skill. He called it the Land of Heroes, *Kalevala*
from Kaleva the mythological ancestor of all the heroes. It consisted of
twenty-five Runos (or Cantos): this was enlarged with new collected ma-
terial to double, and published again in 1849, and almost immediately
appeared in translation in other languages.

It is interesting to realize however that this ballad-singing, neverthe-
less, still goes on: that those ballads here by chance crystallized for us
are capable of and still undergo a thousand variations. The *Kalevala*,
too, is by no means all the ballad literature of Finland and is not even
the whole of the collected ballads even of Lönnrot, who published as
well a whole volume of them under the name of "Kanteletar" or the
"Daughter of the Harp." The *Kalevala* is only different in this that it is
connected and so more readable, and covers most of the field of Finnish
mythology from the Genesis of Earth and Sky to the departure of Väinä-
moinen. The lateness of its collection is apt to make those with a prob-
ably unwholesome modern thirst for the "authentically primitive" feel
doubtful. It is however very likely the real reason why the treasure house
remained unrifled: it was not redecorated or upholstered, whitewashed
or otherwise spoilt: it was left to the care of chance; to the genius of the
fire-side and escaped the pedant and the instructive person.

Even when collected and at last suffering the fate of reproduction in print these poems by luck escaped being handled roughly or moralistically. It is a startling literature to be so popular among that now most law-abiding and most Lutheran of European peoples. [Jumala, whose name translates God in the Bible, is still in the Kalevala the God of clouds and rain, the old man of the sky, the guardian of the many Daughters of Creation]—It is very parallel to the interest of Icelandic Bishops in the adventures [of] Thörr and Óðinn; it is hardly an instance as I have heard claimed, of the still struggling presence of paganism in Modern Europe under Christianity or later of Hebraic biblicality.

III

The language of these poems, Finnish, makes a strong bid for the place of most difficult in Europe: though it is anything but ugly, in fact it suffers like many languages of its type from an excess of euphony: so much so that the music of language is apt to be expended automatically and leave no excess with which to heighten the emotion of a lyric passage. Where vowel harmony and the softening of consonants is an integral part of ordinary speech, there is less chance for sudden unexpected sweetnesses. It is a language practically isolated in Europe except for the related and neighbouring Estonia whose stories and whose tongue are very closely akin. (I am told it bears relation to tribal speeches in Russia, to Magyar, to Turkish in the far distance). It bears no relation to either of its neighbours except in process of borrowing: it is too a language of a type altogether more primitive than most in Europe. It still partakes of a flexible fluid unfixed state inconceivable in English. In the poetry meaningless syllables and even meaningless words that just sound jolly are freely inserted. In such lines as

“Enkä lähe Inkerelle
Penkerelle Pänkerelle”
or
“Ihveniä ahvenia
Tuimienia Taimenia”

are possible where *pänkerelle* merely echoes *Penkerelle* and *Ihveniä*: *Tuimienia* are merely invented to set off *ahvenia* and *taimienia*.

Its metre is roughly the same as that of the translation though much freer: octosyllabic lines with about four stresses (two main ones usually two subordinate). It is of course the unrhymed trochaic metre of “Hiawatha”. This was pirated as was the idea of the poem and much of the incident (though none of its spirit at all) by Longfellow—a fact which I merely mention because it is usually kept dark in biographical notices of that poet. “Hiawatha” is not a genuine storehouse of Indian folklore,

but a mild and gentle bowdlerising of the Kalevala coloured, I imagine, with disconnected bits of Indian lore and perhaps a few genuine names. Longfellow's names are often too good to be inventions. It was either Longfellow's second or third journey to Europe (the one whose object was the acquiring of Danish and Swedish) that connected with the Kalevala's first rush into translations in Scandinavian and German. The pathos I think only of the Kalevala finds anything like an equal reflection in its imitator (a gentle mild and rather dull American don the author of "Evangeline") "who the London Daily News (I am now quoting an American appreciation) admitted had produced one of the most marvellous lines in all English: "Chanting the Hundredth Psalm that Grand old Puritan Anthem".

This metre, monotonous and thin as can be, is indeed if well handled capable of the most poignant pathos (if not of more majestic things). I do not mean the "Death of Minnehaha" but in the Kalevala the "Fate of Aino" and the "Death of Kullervo", where it is enhanced, not hindered, by the to us humorous naïveté of the unsophisticated mythological surroundings. Pathos is common in the Kalevala—often very true and keen. One of the favourite subjects—not a majestic one but very well handled—is the other side to a wedding which the "happy ever after" style of literature usually avoids:—the lament and heartsinking even of a willing bride on leaving her father's house and the familiar things in home. This in the state of society reflected in the "Land of Heroes" was evidently near to tragedy, where mothers-in-law were worse than anywhere in literature, and where families dwelt in ancestral homes for generations—sons and their wives all under the iron hand of the Matriarch.

If you are bored of the sing-song character of this metre, as you may well be, it is only well to remember that these are only accidentally as it were written things; they are in essence sing-songs chanted to the harp as the singers swayed backwards and forwards in time. There are many allusions to this custom: as for instance at the beginning:

"Let us clasp our hands together

Let us interlock our fingers

Let us sing a cheerful measure

Let us use our best endeavours

* * * * *

And recall our songs and legends

of the belt of Väinämöinen

of the forge of Ilmarinen

and of Kaukomieli's sword point."

IV

The Religion of these poems is a luxuriant animism—it can hardly be separated from the purely mythological, therefore this means that in the Kalevala every stock and stone, every tree, the birds, waves, hills, air, the tables, swords and the beer even have well defined personalities which it is one of the quaint merits of the poems to bring out with singular skill and aptness in numerous “speeches in part.” The most remarkable of these is the speech of the sword to Kullervo before he throws himself upon its point. If a sword had a character you feel it would be just such as is pictured there: a cruel and cynical ruffian (see Runo 36/320), There is also the mention of a few other cases, the lament of the Birch Tree; or the passage (reminiscent of “Hiawatha” but better) where Väinämöinen seeks a tree to give him timber for his boat (Runo XVI). This is one of the most essential features of the whole poem; even ale talks on occasion—as in a passage I hope to have time to read, the story of the Origin of Beer (Runo XX 522/546).

The Kalevaläic idea of Beer is often enthusiastically expressed but the oft-repeated “The Ale is of the finest, best of Drinks for prudent people” implies (as also the rest of the poems do) a certain moderation. The joys of Teutonic drunkenness do not seem to have appealed so much as other vices; though drink’s value in setting free the imagination (and the tongue) was often praised (Runo 21. 260):

“O thou Ale thou drink delicious
Let the drinkers be not moody
Urge the people on to singing;
Let them shout with mouths all golden
Till our lords shall wonder at it,
And our ladies ponder o’er it.
For the songs already falter,
And the joyous tongues are silenced
When the Ale is ill-concocted,
And bad drink is set before us;
Then the minstrels fail in singing
And the best of songs they sing not,
And our cherished guests are silent,
And the cuckoos call no longer.”

But beyond this there is a wealth of mythology; every tree, wave and hill again has its nymph and spirit (distinct from the character apparently of each individual object). There is the nymph of blood and the veins, the spirit of the rudder; there is Moon and his children, the Sun and his (they are both masculine). There is a dim and awesome figure (the near-

est approach to regal dignity) Tapio God of the Forest and his spouse Mielikki, with their fairylike son and daughter “Tellervo little maiden of the Forest clad in soft and beauteous garments” and her brother Nyyrikki with his red cap and blue coat; there is Jumala or Ukko in the heavens and Tuoni in the earth or rather in some vague dismal region beside a river of strange things. Ahti and his wife Vellamo dwell in the waters and there are a thousand new and quaint characters for acquaintance—Pakkanen the frost, Lempo the god of evil, Kankahatar the goddess of weaving—but a catalogue does not I am afraid inspire the uninitiated and bores the others. The division between the offspring of the nymphs and sprites—you cannot really call them gods it is much too Olympic—and the human characters is hardly clearly drawn at all. Väinämöinen, most human of liars, most versatile and hardy of patriarchs, who is the central figure, is the son of the Wind and of Ilmatar (daughter of the Air). Kullervo most tragic of peasant boys is but two generations from a swan.

I give you just this jumble of gods great and small to give some impression of the delightful atmosphere into which you plunge in the *Kalevala*—in case some have never plunged. If you are not of the temperament—or think you are not designed for getting on well with these divine personages, I assure you they behave most charmingly, and all obey the great Rule of the Game in the *Kalevala* which is to tell at least three lies before imparting any accurate information however trivial. It had become I think a kind of formula of polite behaviour, for no one seems to believe you until your fourth statement (which you modestly preface with “all the truth I now will tell you, though at first I lied a little”).

V

So much for religion, if you can call it such, and the imaginary background. The real scenery of the poems, the place of most of its action is Suomi the Marshland; Finland [sic] as we call it or as the Finns often call is the Land of Ten Thousand Lakes. Short of going there I imagine one could scarcely get a better picture of the land than the *Kalevala* gives (of the land a century ago at any rate, if not of modern progress); it is instinct with love of it: of its bogs and wide marshes in which stand kind of islands formed by rising ground or by hills topped with trees perhaps. The bogs are always before you or beside you and a worsted or outwitted hero is always thrown into one. One sees the lakes and reed-fenced flats with slow rivers; the perpetual fishing; the pile-built houses—and then in winter the land covered with sleighs and men faring over quick and firm alike on snow-shoes. Juniper, Pine fir, aspen, birch, scarce the oak, seldom any other tree, are continually mentioned; and whatever they be nowadays in Finland the bear and wolf are persons of great importance

in the “Kalevala” and many sub-arctic animals besides which we do not know in Britain.

The customs are all strange and the colours; the pleasures and the dangers different. Cold on the whole is regarded with the greatest horror, and perpetual steaming hot baths are one of the greatest daily features. The Sauna or bath-house (a quite separate and elaborate building affixed to all respectable homesteads) has I believe from time immemorial been a characteristic of Finnish dwellings. They take these hot and often. Society is composed of prosperous homesteads and scattered villages; the poems deal with the highest life but that is only with the life of the richer farms separated a little from the village. Nothing causes more violent anger to any of the heroes than for his wife to demean herself by going to talk “down in the village”. It reflects a quiet and moderately contented people but shorn of all the higher and more majestic aspects of national life or tradition; they are governed from above by an alien power. Rarely does such a word as king come in; there is no courtly grandeur, no castles (where they are mentioned it is often mere bad translation).

Patriarchs, stout yeomen with white beards are the most majestic figures to be seen (when their wife is not there). The power of mothers is the most arresting characteristic. Even old Väinämöinen consults his mother on most occasions of difficulty: this tying to the apron-strings goes on even after death; and instructions are issued occasionally from the grave. The housewife’s opinion is universally put first. The feelings towards mothers and sisters are far the most genuine and deep and powerful throughout. A confirmed villain of loose morals and wife-beating propensities as the lively Lemminkäinen (as he is always called) shows only his best and most and affectionate feelings to his mother. The great tragedy of Kullervo (the reckless peasant boy) is one of brother and sister.

Beyond Finland we are often carried in sleighs or boats, or by more swift and magic means, to Pohja, a mirky misty marshland country, sometimes evidently thought of as Lappland, more often it is no one seems clear where: whence magic comes and all manner of marvels; where Luohi [sic] dwells who hid the Sun and Moon. Sweden, the Lapps, Estonia are often mentioned: Saxony (which is our present enemy) rarely and distantly. Russia our ally not often and usually unpleasantly; of a heartless virago of a wife it is said “all estranged is now thy brother and his wife is like a Russian”; and of the most desperate and miserable life it is said to be “as a prisoner lives in Russia only that the jail is wanting.”

VI

I have now tried to suggest without any describing of plot or retailing of tit-bits to hint at the style and quality of the Kalevala, the Land of

Heroes. Its style of course largely depends on all these beliefs and social characteristics I have talked of: there are however some very curious traits of a more accidental and individual character which so colour the whole that they seem worth mentioning before I cease from my meandering discourse. There is the curious thing I should like to call “super-adding” by which often a comparison as even after a statement to the next line contains a great enlargement of it, often with reckless alteration of detail or fact: colors, metals, names are piled up not for their distinct representation of ideas so much as just for the emotional effect. There is a strange and often effectively lavish use of the words gold and silver and honey which are strewn up and down the lines. Colours are rarer; rather do we get gold and silver, moonlight and sunlight, an intense delight in both of which is frequently breaking forth.

There are many such details as these; the incantations, or prayers of deprecation are more essential: they perpetually recur in the presence of any evil of evil feared, and vary from five lines to five hundred, which is the length of the splendid “Kine-song” of Ilmarinen’s wife; while most delightful too are “songs of origin”—you have only got to know the accurate detailed history of the origin birth and ancestry of anyone (I don’t say any thing because there is practically no such distinction for the Kalevala) to have the power to stop the evil and cure the damage he has done or otherwise deal with him. The songs of the “Origin of Iron” and the “Origin of Beer” are the most delightful.

To conclude—although it is clear that to our artificial rather over-selfconscious modern taste, a lot of cheap smiles can be got out of these poems (above all out of a bad or mediocre translation)—yet that is not the attitude in which I wish to put them before you. There is a certain humour (in conversation between characters and so forth) which it is justifiable to smile at, but it is really to incur laughter for [our] own weakness, our own dulled vision, as of old age, if we laugh too lightly at the simplicity of the balder passages of the Land of Heroes: unless indeed we laugh for pleasure at the finding of something so fresh and delightful. But there are passages which are not only entertaining stories of magic and adventure, quaint myths, or legend; but which are truly lyrical and delightful even in translation, and this high poetical feeling is continually occurring in lines, or couplets, or numbers of lines up and down the Runos but so unlevel as to make purple passage quotation useless. The episodes too and situations are by no means inferior (often vastly superior) to the ballads of much more famous countries than Finland. We are dealing with a popular poetry: overburdened with no technique; unconscious and uneven.

But the delight of Earth, the wonder of it; the essential feeling as of the necessity for magic; that juggling with the golden moon and silver

sun (such are they) that is man’s universal pastime: these are the things to seek in the Kalevala. All the world to wheel about in, the Great Bear to play with and Orion and the Seven Stars all dangling magically in the branches of a silver birch enchanted by Väinämöinen; the splendid sorcerous scandalous villains of old to tell of when you have walked into “Sauna” after binding the kine at close of day with pastures of little Suomi in the Marshes.

[The formal text apparently ends here, but the following page is clearly sequential and contains an introduction and notes for passages to be read aloud. Ed.]

VII

Quotation

The translation I am going to use is that of the “Everyman” series (2 vols) W.H. Kirby: who sometimes seems to plump unnecessarily for the prosy and verbally preposterous, though the great difficulty of course, of the original style is hard to exaggerate. As far as I can see, he seems to have tried as nearly as possible the task of making each line correspond to each line of the original which hasn’t improved things; but occasionally he is very good indeed. If anyone does not know the story (and there is time) I can scarcely do better than read the bald summary in the preface of this edition.

Passages:

The favourites among the Finns are the episodes of “Aino” and “Kullervo”

- 1) Aino R. III 530 (circ) to end; R. IV (140-190) 190-470
- 2) Kullervo R. 31 1-200; 34 1-80; 35 (170) 190-290; 36 (60-180; 280-end
- 3) The Kine-Song (cp. above page)
32 60-160; 210-310
(This includes the classic example of “wheedling”; the bear of course is the most hated of all animals to the farmer’s wife; this is how she addresses him.)
32:310-370; 390-430; 450-470
- 4) Origin of Iron IX 20-260
- 5) Origin of Beer XX 140-250; 340-390
- (6) Forging of Sampo X 260-430
- (7) Great Ox XX 1-80
- (8) Joukahainen III 270-490
- 9) Tormenting of the Bride XXII 20-120; (130-190) (290-400—)

NOTES AND COMMENTARY

not originally written for this society. See editor's Introduction. Tolkien first delivered this talk to the Sundial Society of Corpus Christi College, Oxford, on 22 November 1914. He gave it again to the Essay Club of Exeter College in February of 1915 and the present text is the one given then.

the sudden collapse of the intended reader. I have been unable to find any further information on the identity of the reader or the nature of the collapse.

literature. Tolkien uses this spelling throughout, chiefly in abbreviations, as "litt." His usage may be a deliberate allusion to Latin *litteratura*, which many years later (in his 1959 "Valedictory Address") he equated with Greek *grammatike* and *philologia* as "the study of grammar and idiom, and the critical study of authors (largely concerned with their language)" (MC 232). A few lines later in the same paragraph he distinguished "the word 'literature' more narrowly" to mean writings with "artistic purpose or form" (MC 233). The emphasis placed on language by the first usage is of a piece with his contention that "Mythology is language and language is mythology" (TOFS 181)."

the original which is vastly different to any translation. While at Exeter College, Tolkien checked out a Finnish grammar from the library in order to try to read *Kalevala* in its original language. He was already, it would seem, working on the theory expressed in Manuscript A of "On Fairy-stories" that "Mythology is language and language is mythology" (OFS 181).

Stead's Books for the Bairns. A series of books for young people published by W.T. Stead, an English journalist, philanthropist and politician, Books for the Bairns repackaged classics, fairy tales, fables, nursery rhymes, Great Events in British History, and the Gospels, giving them all a moral and Christian perspective aimed at reforming the world. Books for the Bairns, First Series 1806-1920, were well-known to young people of Tolkien's generation.

the above beloved pink covers. While there are no pink covers mentioned "above," Tolkien's later typewritten essay notes that Stead's Books for the Bairns had pink covers.

Indo-european languages. The Indo-European language theory, derived from nineteenth-century comparative philology and mythology, reconstructed by phonological correspondences and principles of sound-

change a hypothetical pre-historic language called Proto-Indo-European from which the modern Indo-European language families have derived. Finnish, related to Hungarian and (distantly) to Turkish) is not Indo-European but Finno-Ugric.

Thorfinn in Vinland the good. Thorfinn Karlsefni was an eleventh-century Icelander who tried to establish a colony in “Vinland,” previously so named by Leif Eriksen and thought to be somewhere on the north-east coast of North America. His expedition is mentioned in two fourteenth-century Icelandic manuscripts, the *Hauksbók*, and the *Flatýjarbók* (Flat-island Book)

the clumsiness of a translation. Not only did Tolkien dislike Kirby’s translation, his stated principle that “Mythology is language and language is mythology” (see entry for “original translation” above) would invalidate any translation of a work as faithfully representing the original.

when I first read the Kalevala. According to both Humphrey Carpenter and John Garth, Tolkien first read Kirby’s translation some time in 1911, his last year at King Edward’s School. He went up to Oxford in the autumn of that year, and checked out Charles Eliot’s Finnish Grammar from the Exeter College Library.

Andaman Isles. The Andaman Isles, a territory of India, are situated in the Indian Ocean halfway between the Indian subcontinent and Southeast Asia. In *Custom and Myth*, Andrew Lang twice refers to Andaman Islanders, first querying: “If a tertiary troglodyte was like a modern Andaman Islander . . . would he stand and meditate in awe on the fact that a tree was taller than he . . . ?” (233); and next suggesting that, “If the history of religion and of mythology is to be unravelled, we must examine what the unprogressive classes in Europe have in common with Australians and Bushmen and Andaman Islanders” (241). Worth noting is Tolkien’s much later suggestion in both the A and B drafts of “*Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics*” (conjecturally dated by Drout to c. 1933–35) that contemporary critics might substitute “Andaman-islanders . . . for Anglo-Saxons” (*B&C* 33, 81).

Hausa Folktales.

The Hausa are a Sahelian people occupying a territory ranging over Northeastern Nigeria and Southeastern Niger. In *The British Folklorists: A History*, Richard Dorson notes that “Within a five-year period, 1908–1913, four folklore and language collections were published on the Hausa” (368). Dorson cites Major Arthur John Newman Tremearne’s *Hausa Folktales*, published in 1914. An article entitled “Hausa Folktales” by “F.W.H.M.” appeared in the journal *African Affairs*, Oxford University

Press, 1914; XIII 457. Appearing at the time when Tolkien was writing, these would have been available to him. The skeptical view of comparative mythology here expressed foreshadows Tolkien's later and equally dismissive opinion of the comparative approach in his essay "On Fairy-stories."

Hon. Mods. Classical Honour Moderations, a first round of examinations at Oxford University, in which the student can get a First (highly desirable), a Second (good but not great), and a Third (a weak pass). Tolkien got a Second.

Troilus to need a Pandarus. Tolkien could be thinking of the story as told in Chaucer's poem *Troilus and Criseyde* or in Shakespeare's play *Troilus and Cressida*. In both works, Cressida's uncle, Pandarus, acts as go-between for the lovers.

queer troglodyte story. The primary meaning of troglodyte is "cave-dweller" (from Greek *trogle*, "hole," with the extended sense "hermit," Tolkien presumably meant a story which has been isolated from the rest of society. Also see the usage by Andrew Lang in the entry above for Andaman Isles.

the Mabinogion. The great literary repository of Welsh mythology. It exists for the most part in two manuscripts, the White Book of Rhydderch (*Llyfr Gwyn Rhydderch*, A.D. 1300-1325) and the Red Book of Hergest (*Llyfr Coch Hergest*, 1375-1425). It was translated into English by Lady Charlotte Guest in 1838-49. Tolkien had copies of all three volumes.

Väinämöinen. The primeval singer and oldest culture-hero, first of the "big three" heroes of *Kalevala*, the other two being Ilmarinen the smith and Lemminkäinen the rascally playboy. Väinämöinen is the first-born and most folkloric of the three, having aspects of shamanism in his character.

Elias Lönnrot in 1835 made a selection. In 1835 Elias Lönnrot, a Finnish physician and folklore collector, published the *Old Kalevala*, a selection from his extensive collection of *runos* or songs.

Lönnrot was not the only collector. Earlier collectors included Zachris Topelius, Matthias Castrén, Julius Krohn, and Krohn's son Kaarle Krohn. For a complete discussion see Domenico Comparetti, *Traditional Poetry of the Finns*, London: Longmans Green, 1898, and Juha Pentikäinen, *Kalevala Mythology*, trans. Ritva Poom, Indiana University Press, 1989.

published again in 1849. The augmented, standard edition of *Kalevala*

from which all current translations are made.

the Kalevala’s first rush into translations in Scandinavian and German. There was indeed a “rush into translations” starting with a translation into Swedish of the Old (1835) Kalevala by Matthias Castrén (a Finn) in 1841. In 1845 Jakob Grimm included thirty-eight lines from Runo 19 in a presentation to the German Academy of Sciences, and a complete translation into German of the New (1849) Kalevala was produced by Anton Schiefner in 1852.

“Chanting the Hundredth Psalm that Grand old Puritan Anthem.” Tolkien’s syntax makes it hard to figure out exactly who said what about what, but apparently an “American appreciation” quoted the *London Daily News* as praising Longfellow’s “The Courtship of Miles Standish” for containing “one of the most marvelous lines in all English.” The line in question (misquoted in Tolkien’s text) describes Priscilla, the object of the Courtship, “singing the hundredth Psalm, the grand old Puritan anthem.” Equally unclear is the object of Tolkien’s obvious sarcasm, whether it is the American appreciator of the quote, the *London Daily News* for its taste in poetry, or Longfellow for calling a Hebrew Psalm a “Puritan anthem.” Or all of the above.

Ilmarinen. One of the “big three” heroes of *Kalevala*. His name is formed from *ilma*, “sky,” with the occupational suffix *ni*. He has the epithets *seppo*, “craftsman,” and *takoja*, “hammerer, forger.” He was originally the maker of the sky, Finnish *kürjökansi* the “decorated/many-colored lid” and is the forger of the Sampo, the mysterious creation which is the object of desire in *Kalevala*.

Kaukomieli. A by-name or epithet for Lemminkainen, the reckless playboy, third of the “Big Three.” Magoun translates Kaukomieli as “man with a far-roving mind”; Friburg as “far-minded,” Kuusi, Bosley and Branch as “far-sighted” or “proud.”

“speeches in part.” A convention of folk tale and folk poetry in which inanimate but personified objects have voices and speak for themselves, or to (or about) human characters. The harp in “Jack and the Beanstalk” telling its owner that Jack is stealing it is an example. Tolkien used the convention in *The Hobbit* when he had the Trolls’ purse speak to Bilbo (who is trying to steal it).

Ahti . . . in the waters. Tolkien has got the wrong spelling here, and consequently the wrong figure. He means Ahto, who is listed in Kirby as “the God of the Sea and of the Waters.” Ahti is a by-name for Lemminkainen.

The Kalevala

[*Typescript draft*]

I am afraid this paper was not originally written for this society, which I hope it will pardon since I produce it mainly to form a stop-gap to night, and to entertain you as far as possible in spite of the sudden collapse of the proper speaker. I hope you will also forgive, besides its second-hand character its quality—which is hardly that of a paper, rather a disconnected soliloquy accompanied by a leisurely patting on the back of a pet volume. If I continually drop into talking of these poems as if no one in the room had ever heard of them but myself, you must attribute it to the strange chance that no one had when I read the paper before; and you must also attribute it to the “pet”-attitude. I am very fond of these poems—they are literature so very unlike any of the things that are familiar to general readers, or even those who stray in the more curious by-paths—they are so very un-European, and yet could only come from Europe.

Anyone who has read the collection of ballads which go by this name (more especially if he has read them, or even part of them, in the original—a vastly different thing to any translation) will I think agree to that. Most people are familiar from the days of their earliest books onwards with the general mould and type of mythological stories, legends, tales, romances, and so on, that come to us by many and crooked channels from ancient Hellas and the southern lands, from the North and the grim Germanic peoples, from the islands of the West and their old Celtic lords (whatever Celtic may mean). For some of us, for more than are often willing or honest enough to confess it, these achieved their crowning glory and delight in Stead’s pink-covered Books for the Bairns—that mine of ancient and undying lore. They have a certain style, or savour; a something akin to one another in them, in spite of their vast cleavages; a something that is more than the universal community of human imagination, and that makes you feel that, whatever the ultimate differences of race of those speakers, there is something kindred in the imagination of the speakers of Indo-european languages. Some far off things there were, of course, even in those little pink books; echoes from the black heart of Africa; trickles from a distant and alien East. Nothing in this world can be finally defined, or marked out with rigid lines. So it is with Europe. It has south-eastern frontiers over which have perpetually poured the influences, half-asiatic, half close kindred to ourselves, of the Semitic languages and cultures to be assimilated swiftly and often beyond easy recognition in Europe. But that is an old tale; and even perhaps while we are still arguing whether the Far East has given us more than a

plot here, the shadow of an old tale there to be turned to our own uses, you come one very fine day upon the Kalevala, the Land of Heroes. Then you are indeed in a quite new world and can revel in an amazing new excitement.

We will avoid the Peak in Darien, of only for the reason that I at any rate am not remaining silent about/upon it—still you do feel a Columbus landing on a new continent, a Thorfinn Karlsefni in a Vinland the Good—and better off, for your new heroic acquaintances are better fun than Skraeling or Red Indian. Of course when you first step onto the new ground you can, if you like, at once begin comparing it with the places you have come from. There are mountains, rivers, grass, and other things here much as there were there; many plants and some animals (especially the ferocious human species) may seem familiar—but it is more than likely that an indefinable sense of newness will either delight or disturb you too much for comparisons, there will be a glamour of strangeness even upon the familiar things; the trees will group themselves unusually on the horizon; the birds will make unfamiliar music; the inhabitants will talk a wild and at first unintelligible lingo. After the country and its manners have become better known to you, and you have got on speaking terms with the natives, you will, I hope, find it jolly to live awhile with this strange people and these new gods, with this race of unhypocritical low-brow scandalous heroes, and sadly unsentimental lovers—some there may be who will think with regret that they have ever to go back from that land at all. There are possibly some, however, that I have not yet considered, people of irreproachable education and faultless urbanity who would desire only to catch the first liner back to their familiar cities. These people had better be off soon. I have no defence to offer them for the "Land" or its "Heroes"; for to them it is useless to say that, if the heroes of the Kalevala do behave with a singular lack of dignity and even decency, and with a readiness for tears and dirty dealing, that is part of their especial attraction! After all they are not really more undignified—and are much more easy to get on with—than is a medieval lover who takes to his bed to lament the cruelty of his lady in that she will not have pity on him, condemning him to a melting death; but who is struck with the novelty of the idea when his kindly adviser points out that the poor lady is as yet uninformed in any way of his attachment. The lovers of Kalevala are forward and take a deal of rebuffing. There is no Troilus to need a Pandarus to do his shy wooing for him; rather here it is the mothers-in-law who do some sound bargaining behind the scenes, and give cynical advice to their daughters calculated to shatter the stoutest illusions.

Wonder and a little bewilderment were at any rate my experience when I first came upon the Kalevala—crossed, that is, the gulf between

the Indo-european-speaking peoples of Europe into the smaller realm of those who still cling in queer corners to half-forgotten tongues and memories of an elder day. The newness worried me, sticking in awkward lumps through the clumsiness of a translation that had not overcome all the peculiar difficulties of its task; it irritated while it attracted—but the more I read of it, the more I felt at home and enjoyed myself. Then I made a wild assault on the original language, and was at first repulsed with heavy losses, and can never be said to have taken the position. Still it is easy to see why translations are not very good, or very near to their original—they are dealing with a language separated by an immeasurable gulf in nature and in method of expression from English. Finnish is an odd tongue, very fitting to the “Land of Heroes” (as is natural), and as different from anything that you are familiar with as the tales of these poems are from the tales you knew before.

One repeatedly hears the “Land of Heroes” described as the Finnish National Epic—as if it was of the nature of the universe that every nation (dreary word), besides a national bank, and government, should before qualifying for membership of the League, show lawful possession also of a National Epic, hall-remark of respectability, evidence indeed of national existence. But Finland does not possess one. The Kalevala certainly is not one. It is a mass of conceivably epic material (I can conceive of the epic that should grow with difficulty from it, I must confess); but—and I think this is the main point—it would lose all that is its greatest delight, if ever it were one unhappy day to be epically handled. The mere stories, bare events, alone could remain; all that undergrowth, that rich profusion and luxuriance, which clothe them would have to be stripped away. Indeed, the “Land of Heroes” is a collection of exactly that absorbingly delightful material which on the appearance of an epic artist, and of an age lofty-minded enough to produce him, has elsewhere inevitably been cast aside, and fallen at last out of even “oral literature” into disuse and final oblivion. Barely in the Kalevala do passages or episodes appear than one can conceive of as capable of being tuned to the higher emotional pitches required by the greater poetry. It is to all that body of strange myth, of queer troglodyte underworld of story, of wild jugglings with the sun and moon and the origins of the earth and the shapes of Man, that in Homer (for instance) has lightly been pruned away till only a few incongruous traces of its former presence are left—it is to this that most of the Kalevala may be compared and not to the large grandeur of the epic theme, nor to its conscious humanity. Or again it is to the weird tales, the outrageous ghosts, and the sorceries and by-tracks of Northern imagination that crop out at times into the usually intensely clear upper air of the Sagas that the Land of Heroes can most often be likened, not to the haughty dignity and courage, the nobility of mind and of body of

which the great Sagas tell. Yet the queer and strange, the unrestrained the grotesque is not only interesting it is valuable: it is one of the eternal and permanent interests and attractions of men. Nor is it always necessary to purge it all out in order to attain to the sublime. You can have your gargoyles on our noble cathedral; but northern Europe has lost much through too often trying to build Greek temples. To night I am not in the least concerned however even to be sublime—I am content to turn over the pages of these mythological ballads—full of that very primitive undergrowth that the literature of Europe has on the whole been steadily cutting away and reducing for many centuries with different and earlier completeness among different people[.] I would that we had more of it left—something of the same sort that belonged to the English—but my desire is not due to one very dreadful and fatal motive; it is not adulterated with science; it is clear of all suspicion of Anthropology. Any such collection as this would be, and indeed I am only too well aware is, the playground of anthropologists and comparative mythologists, where they luxuriate mightily awhile—but however good and interesting in its own way their sport and hunting may be (I fear I am often sceptical) it is as foreign to my present purpose as would be the processes of the manufacture of cheese. Commentators, I know, make many notes to these poems such as: “compare this story with the one told in the Andaman Isles”, or “compare that belief with the one mentioned in the Hausa folk-tales”, and so forth—but don’t let us. These notes seldom prove anything more than that Finns and Andaman Islanders are though rather different to look at nearly related animals, and that we knew before. Let us rather be glad that we have come suddenly upon a storehouse of this popular imaginings that we had feared lost, stocked with stories not yet sophisticates into a sense of proportion, with no thought of the decent limits even of exaggeration, with no sense (or certainly not our sense) of the incongruous, unless, as we may at times suspect, incongruity is delighted in. We are taking a holiday from the whole course of European progress of the last three milleniums, and going to be wildly un-hellenic and barbarous for a time—like the boy who hoped that the future life would provide for half-holidays in Hell far away from Eton collars and hymns. For the moment we are not to apply our superior modern intellect to the analyzing of these things. We should rather try to enter into their especial spirit on terms of equality. The vivisectionist is able to make a case out for himself, but no one believes that he knows more about dogs that the man that keeps them as pets—but even the superiority that enters into the word pet should be got rid of—I should have said who makes a companion of a dog. The only analysis I have allowed myself is a gentle probing into my own feelings of pleasure into the savour perceived in these poems; some little effort to describe the life the landscape and the

people of this land as they presented themselves to me.

The delicious exaggerations of these wild tales could no doubt be learnedly compared to a hundred primitive or modern uncivilized literatures, and collections of legend—but, even if I could, I wouldn't for the present move outside Europe; for however wild, uncivilized and primitive these things may be their atmosphere and landscape belong essentially to Northern Europe, and to emphasize that I would willingly forgo a hundred parallelisms. It is all the same true that the unrestraint and exaggeration in the *Kalevala* does at once recall such things as say the Welsh stories of the *Mabinogion*, and other similar things in Welsh and Irish; but in reality their cases are very different. In the *Kalevala* there is often no attempt at even the limited plausibility of the fairy-tale no cunning concealment of the impossible—only the child's delight in saying that he has cut down a million trees, or that he will knock down some such august personage as his father, if indeed he has not already slain twenty policemen. All this is not intended to take you in, nor even to cast the brief spell of the story-teller's illusion over you. Its delight depends on the dawning perception of the limits of ordinary human possibility and at the same time of the limitless power of movement and of creation of the human fancy and imagination. Latent in it no doubt is the heroism of the human battles with overmastering fate, and courage undaunted by unconquerable odds—but you do not listen to it on that account, you either like it or despise it as an effort of fresh unsophisticated fancy. Of course in the Welsh tales there is often, indeed continually, in evidence the same delight in a picturesque lie, in a strong breathless flight of fancy; but paradoxically the Welsh tales are both far more absurd and far less so than the Finnish. They are more absurd for they are (when we get them) less fresh than they once were; there is in many places a thick dust of a no longer understood tradition lying on them; strings of names and allusions that no longer have any meaning, that were already nonsense for the bards who related them. Any one who wants to see what I mean has only to look at the catalogue of the heroes of Arthur's court in the story of *Kilhwch and Olwen*, or the account of the feats that *Kilhwch* had to perform for the giant *Yspaddaden Penkawr* in order to win his daughter *Olwen*. There is little or nothing of this strange lumber in the *Kalevala*. On the other hand, the Welsh stories are far less absurd for the pictures painted have far more technique; their colours are cleverly, even marvelously schemed; their figures are cunningly grouped. The fairy-tale's own plausibility is respected; if a man slays an impossible monster, the story holds firm to its lie. In the *Land of Heroes* a man may kill a gigantic elk in one line and find it more poetic to call it a she-bear in the next. To elaborate this is perhaps unnecessary; but it might be made the occasion of an attempt to say just what I find the atmosphere of the *Kalevala* to

be—my finding you can correct for yourselves from your own knowledge, or from the extracts that I could wish to read to you until your patience was exhausted, and you felt the appropriateness of the last lines of the Kalevala:

"Een the waterfall when flowing
Yields no endless stream of water;
Nor does an accomplished singer
Sing till all his knowledge fail him."

It seems to me that what one feels immediately is that there is no background of literary or artistic tradition. The Mabinogion, for instance, has such a background; it is full of the sense of long years of development and even of decay which has resulted, on the one hand, in the cumbering of the tale with forgotten traditional names and matter, and on the other has produced a field of the most excellently harmonised and subtly varied colours against which the figures of the actors stand out—but they also harmonise with the marvellous surrounding colour-scheme and lose in startlingness if not in clearness. If few have the same intensely vivid feeling for colour that Keltic tales show, yet most similar national legendary literatures have something of this—the Kalevala to me feels to have none. The colours, the deeds, the marvels, the figures of the heroes are all splashed onto a clean bare canvas by a sudden hand; even the legends concerning the origin of the most ancient things in the world seem to come fresh from the singer's hot imagination of the moment. Certainly there are no modernities in it like trams or guns or aeroplanes; the heroes' weapons it is true are the so-called antique bow and spear and sword, but at the same time there is a "nowness", a quite unhazy unromantic momentariness and presentness that startles you mightily when you suddenly realize that you are all the time reading about the earth being made out of a teal's egg, or of the sun and moon being imprisoned in a mountain. All things must be bought at a price and we have purchased the comparat[ive] consistency and reasonableness of our tales, the clearer crystallization of our traditions with the loss of this magic and untarnished freshness.

Now as to what is known of the origin of these poems I know little and will not try to tell much more than I know. Ever since the coming of Väinämöinen and the making of his great harp, the "kantele" fashioned of pike-bone, from what we know of the Finns they have always loved ballads of this sort; and ballads of this sort have been handed on and sung day after day with unending zest from father to son, and from son to grandson down to the present day, when, as the ballads now lament, "the songs are songs of bygone ages, hidden words of ancient wisdom, songs which all the children sing not, all beyond men's comprehension".

The shadow of Sweden and then of Russia has been over the country for many centuries. Petrograd is in Finland. Things are not, it is to be feared, much better now. The remarkable and delightful thing for us, however, is that these “songs of bygone ages” have somehow been preserved without being tinkered with. Sweden finally in the 12th century conquered Finland (or rather the Finns—their land has never had the hard and fast boundaries of the modern European states). Before that there was continual warfare and continual intercourse with the Northerly Germanic peoples that stretches back beyond the beginnings of our era, and in which doubtless the first bearers of the English name in Holstein and the Islands had a good part—but the intercourse goes back even earlier than that far time. By the Swedish conquest, and by the swords of the Teutonic Knights Christianity began slowly to be introduced—in other words the Finns were one of the last acknowledged pagan peoples of Medieval Europe. Today the *Kalevala* and its themes are still practically untouched by this influence, much less affected by it than the mythology of ancient Scandinavia as it appears in the *Edda*. Except in the story of the virgin Marjatta at the end, in a few references to Jumala or Ukko god of the Heavens, and so forth, even hints at the existence of Christianity are almost entirely absent; of its spirit there is nothing, as any one can see who compares the crude story of Marjatta with Christian faith. To this if of course largely ascribable the interesting primitiveness of the poems, the “undergrowth” character of them, though it is also partly responsible for their minor emotional key, their narrow and parochial view—things that in our present holiday mood are not without attraction. For another seven centuries the ballads have been sung in spite of Sweden, in spite of Russia, and do not ever appear to have been written down at all till Elias Lönnröt in 1835 made a collection of many of them, and published a selection of these. These were all collected in Eastern Finland and are consequently in a dialect different from that that has since come to be the modern literary dialect of Finnish. This *Kalevala* dialect has come now to be a kind of poetic convention. Lönnröt was not the only collector, but it was to him that it occurred to string a selection into a loosely connected form—as it would seem from the result with no small skill. He it was who called this string the Land of Heroes, or *Kalevala* from Kaleva the mythological ancestor of all the heroes. It consisted of 25 runos or cantos. This was enlarged with freshly collected material to double the size and published again in 1849, and almost immediately appeared in translation.

With regard to what I have said above it is however well to remember that apart from selection and arrangement these things were taken down straight from the lips of Finnish minstrels, and that the collection did not kill the minstrelsy; the ballad-singing still goes on (or it did until the late

war); those ballads here by chance crystallized for us are capable of, and still undergo, a thousand variations. The Kalevala too is by no means all the ballad-literature of Finland; it is not even the whole of the collection of Lönnröt alone, who published as well another whole volume of them under the name of "Kanteletar" the Daughter of the Harp. The Kalevala is only different in that it is more connected and so more readable, and it covers most of the field of Finnish mythology from the Genesis of Earth and Sky to the departure of Väinämöinen. The lateness of the date of the collection and publication is apt to make those with the (probably not entirely wholesome) modern thirst for the "authentically primitive" doubt whether the wares are quite genuine. Read and doubt no more. Bogus archaism and the pseudo-primitive is as different from this as Ossian is from Middle Irish romance; and anyway the external evidence for the genuineness of these goods is more than sufficient. Indeed the lateness of the collection is very likely the actual reason why the treasure-house has remained unrifled; why its empty shell has not then been whitewashed, redecorated, upholstered in the eighteenth century manner, or otherwise destroyed. It has been left unnoticed to the care of chance, and to the genius of hard-worked uneducated men at the fireside, and has escaped the pedant and the instructive person. More remarkable still, even when collected and suffering at last the fate of reproduction in print, these poems have by luck escaped being roughly or moralistically handled. They have not been twisted into any shape of edification, and remain a very startling sort of reading to be so popular with those now most law-abiding and Lutheran of European peoples, the modern educated Finns. Something of a parallel can be found in the interest of mediaeval Icelandic priests and bishops in the fierce deeds of pre-Christian [*sic*] Scandinavians, and in the often scandalous adventures of Thórr and Óðinn. As a matter of fact one does sometimes hear the Kalevala, and things like it, cited as evidence of the enduring paganism of Europe that (we are told) is still fighting a gallant and holy battle against the oppression of Christianity, and of Hebraic Biblicality. To argue about this would really be to stray far from my present point and purpose; but the temptation to say something about our attitude towards the ancient gods is too strong. Without disputing about the attitude of the Finnish people up to, say, about a century ago when these things were taken down (for I do not know enough about them), I am still quite ready to admit that without something approaching an objective belief in the old gods we definitely lose something of the magic of all old tales, something in them is "all beyond our comprehension"; it is no good saying that the sea is still poetically boundless, for to the very people who can appreciate the poetry of the sea the roundness of the earth and the unfortunate existence of America on the other side of a strictly limited Atlantic ocean

is most constantly and vividly present in the imagination; the heavenly bodies are by them above all most clearly realized not to be the heavenly beings. The organization and greater security of modern life; gentler social manners; a wealth of bodily conveniences, and comforts, and even destructive luxuries; tobacco, doctors, and police; and more (the one thing that is certainly worth it) freedom from the shadow of the darker crueller and fouler superstitions, we have purchased at a price—there are no magic islands in our Western sea and (as Francis Thompson says) “none will again behold Apollo in the forefront of the morning, or see Aphrodite in the upper air loose the long lustre of her golden locks”. We are grown older and must face the fact. The poetry of these old things remains being immortal, but no longer for us is the intoxication of both poetry and belief. The holiday I suggested is a holiday from poetic and literary development, from the long accumulated weight of civilised tradition and knowledge, not a decadent and retrograde movement, not a “nostalgie de la boue”—only a holiday; and if while on this holiday we half hear the voice of Ahti in the noises of the sea, half shudder at the thought of Pohja, gloomy land of witchcraft, or Tuonela yet darker region of the dead, it is nonetheless with quite another part of our minds that we do this than that which we reserve for our real beliefs and for our religion, just as it undoubtedly was for the Icelandic ecclesiastics of old. Yet there may be some whom these old songs will stir to new poetry, just as the old songs of other pagan days have stirred other Christians; for it is true that only the Christians have made Aphrodite utterly beautiful, a wonder for the soul; the Christian poets or those who while renouncing their Christianity owe to it all their feeling and their art have fashioned nymphs and dryads of which not even Greek ever dreamt; the real glory of *Latmos* was made by Keats. As the world grows older there is loss and gain—let us not with modern insolence and blindness imagine it all gain (lest this happen such songs as the “Land of Heroes” are left for our disillusionment); but neither must we with neo-pagan obscurity of thought imagine it all loss.

Returning from my unwarranted digression, I feel that I can not proceed and further without saying something about the language of the poems. Finnish is, for Englishmen at any rate, near the top of the list of the very difficult languages of Europe; though it is anything but ugly. Indeed it suffers like many languages of its type from an excess of euphony; so much so that the music of the language is liable to be expended automatically, and leave over no excess with which to heighten the emotion of a lyric passage. Where vowel-harmony, and the assimilation and softening of consonants is an integral part of ordinary grammar and of everyday speech there is much less chance for sudden unexpected sweetnesses. It is a language practically isolated in modern Europe, except for the language

of the Esthonians which is closely akin, as are their tales and their blood. Finno-Ugrian philology, which is no concern of ours now, discovers a relationship with tribal non-Russian speeches in modern Russia, and in the far distant (though here it is rather a relationship of type than an ultimate kinship of descent) with the Magyar in Hungary, and further still with Turkish. It has no kinship at all with either its immediate Germanic or Slavonic neighbours, except in a process of agelong borrowing that has filled it to the brim with old Slavonic, Lithuanian, and Germanic words, many of which preserve in their new soil the form that they have lost centuries ago in their own tongues—such, for instance, is the case with the Finnish word “*kuningas*” king which is exactly the form that philologists had assumed that our word “king” possessed two thousand years ago or thereabouts. In spite of all this borrowing, and the constant cultural influence of the Indo-european neighbouring languages which has left definite traces, Finnish still remains a language far more primitive (and therefore contrary to the usual superstition far more complicated) than most of the other languages in Europe. It still preserves a flexible fluid unfixed state inconceivable even in the most primitive patois of English. There is no need to search for a more startling example of this than the way in which in the poetry meaningless syllables and even meaningless words that merely sound jolly are freely inserted. For instance in such lines as the following:—

“Enkä lähe Inkerelle
Penkerelle Pänkerelle” —or

“Ihveniä ahvenia
Tuimenia taimenia”

“Pänkerelle” merely echoes “Penkerelle”; “Ihveniä” and “tuimenia” are merely invented to set off “ahvenia” and “taimenia”. I don’t mean to say that this sort of thing is done often enough to reduce the songs to nonsense rhymes with flickers of sense; but the mere fact that such things are possible at all even if it may be for special effect or emphasis is sufficiently astonishing.

The metre employed is roughly the same as that of the translations though much freer and less monotonous than the English would lead one to think. It is the octosyllabic line with roughly four beats or stresses, the rhythm is uniformly trochaic, no upbeat being used, and there is no rhyme. Two of the stresses or beats (usually the first and third) tend to stand out as the most important. It is of course, as far as English can be made to yield the same effect as Finnish, the metre of “*Hiawatha*”. What however is not so generally known is that not only the metre, but the idea of the poem, and much too of the matter and incident, was pirated

for “Hiawatha”—“Hiawatha” is in fact the first literary offspring of the Kalevala, and nothing could better emphasize or illustrate my earlier remarks on the spirit and nature of Finnish songs than a comparison with their civilized descendant. “Hiawatha” is not a genuine storehouse of Indian folklore, but a mild and gentle bowdlerizing of the Kalevala coloured with disconnected bits of Indian lore, and I imagine a few genuine legendary names—some of Longfellow’s names sound altogether too good to be invented. It was either Longfellow’s second or third journey to Europe (the one that had for its object the learning of Danish and Swedish—Longfellow was a professor of Modern languages) that coincided with the Kalevala’s first rush into Scandinavian and German translations.

The pathos alone, I think, of the Kalevala finds anything like an equal reflection in the work of its imitator—a mild and rather dull American don, the author of “Evangeline”, who, “the ‘London Daily News’ (I am quoting now an old American appreciation) admitted had produced one of the most marvellous lines in all English: ‘chanting the Hundredth Psalm, that grand old Puritan anthem’”. This metre, monotonous and thin as it can be (especially in English), is indeed if well handled capable of the most poignant pathos, if not of more majestic things. I don’t mean only the “Death of Minnehaha,” but the “Fate of Aino” in the Kalevala and the “Death of Kullervo,” where this pathos is enhanced not hindered by the (to us) almost humorous naiveté of the mythological and fabulous surroundings. Pathos is common in the Kalevala and often very true and keen. One of the favourite subjects—not a majestic one, but very well handled—is that other side to a wedding that the “happy-ever-after” type of literature usually avoids:— the lament and heart-sinking of even a willing bride on leaving her father’s house and the familiar things of the home. This farewell in the state of society reflected in the Kalevala was evidently often near to tragedy, where mothers-in-law were worse than anywhere else in literature, and where families dwelt in ancestral homes for generations, sons and their wives all under the iron hand of the Matriarch.

If, however, pathos or not, you are bored by the interminable sing-song character of this metre, it is well to remember again that these are only, as it were, accidentally written things—they are in essence song-songs, sing-songs chanted to the monotonous repetition of a phrase thrummed on the harp while the singers swayed backwards and forwards in time.

“Let us clasp our hands together,
Let us interlock our fingers,
Let us sing a cheerful measure,

Let us use our best endeavours
.....
And recall our songs and legends
Of the belt of Väinämöinen,
Of the forge of Ilmarinen,
And of Kaukomieli’s sword-point.”

So opens the *Kalevala*, and there are many other references to the rhythmic swaying of the monotonous chanters: I wish I had ever heard them with my own ears, but I have not.

The religion of the poems—after headings such as “language” and “metre” one feels bound to have another on “religion”—if indeed such a name can be applied to it, is a luxuriant animism; it cannot really be separated from the purely mythological elements. This means that in the *Kalevala* every stock and every stone, every tree, the birds, waves, hills, air, the tables, the swords, and even the beer have well-defined personalities, which it is often the quaint merit of these poems to bring out with singular skill and aptness in numerous speeches in part. One of the most remarkable of these is the speech of his sword to Kullervo just before he throws himself upon its point. If a sword had a character, you feel it would be just such as is pictured there—a cruel and cynical ruffian. There is also, to mention only a few other cases, the lament of the Birch Tree, or the passage (of which the similar passage in *Hiawatha* is an imitation that does not improve upon its model) where Väinämöinen seeks a tree to give him timber for his boat (Runo XVI); or where Lemminkäinen’s mother seeking for her lost son asks all things that she meets for news, the moon, the trees, even the pathway—and they all answer in characterised parts. (Runo XV). This indeed is one of the essential features of the songs: even ale talks on occasions—as in a passage that I hope to have time to read, the story of the origin of Beer. Here is a bit of it (Runo XX 522-556).

“... now the bread they baked was ready, and were stirred the pots
of porridge,
and a little time passed over, when the ale worked in the barrels,
and the beer foamed in the cellars;—‘now must some one come to
drink me,
now must some one come to taste me, that my fame may be
reported,
and that they may sing my praises.’ Then they went to seek a
minstrel,
went to seek a famous singer, one whose voice was of the strongest,
one who knew the finest legends. First to sing they tried a salmon,
if the voice of trout was strongest. Singing is not work for salmon,

and the pike recites no legends. Crooked are the jaws of salmon,
and the teeth of pike spread widely. Yet again they sought a singer,
went to seek a famous singer, one whose voice was of the strongest,
one who knew the finest legends—and they took a child for singer,
thought a boy might sing the strongest. Singing is not work for
children,
nor are splutterers fit for shouting. Crooked are the tongues of
children,
and the roots thereof are crooked. Then the red ale grew
indignant,
and the fresh drink fell to cursing, pent within the oaken barrels,
and behind the taps of copper. ‘If you do not find a minstrel,
do not find a famous singer, one whose voice is of the strongest,
one who knows the finest legends, then the hoops I’ll burst
asunder,
and among the dust will trickle’”

Here we hear not only beer speaking and get a hint at its own estimate of itself as an inspiration of poesy and song, but we hear the Finnish minstrel cracking up his own profession, if with greater quaintness, with greater cunning and subtlety than was normally used by the minstrel of mediaeval England and France in similar passages of advertisement. In the *Kalevala* Beer is the cause of much enthusiasm, but the oft-repeated “ale is of the finest, best of drinks for prudent people” implies (as do the rest of the poems) a certain moderation in the use of good things. The joys of drunkenness at any rate do not seem to have the same appeal as other vices, though good drink’s value in setting free the imagination (and the tongue) was often praised (R. XXI 260).

“ . . . O thou ale thou drink delicious, Let the drinkers be not
moody.
Urge the people on to singing; let them shout with mouths all
golden,
till our lords shall wonder at it, and or ladies ponder o’er it.
For the songs already falter, and the joyous tongues are silenced,
when the ale is ill-concocted, and bad drink is set before us;
then the minstrels fail in singing and the best of songs they sing
not,
and our cherished guests are silent, and the cuckoo calls no longer
. . . ”

Beyond all this personification however there is a wealth of mythology. Every tree, wave, and hill has its nymph and spirit, distinct from the character, apparently, of each individual object. There is the nymph

of the Blood and the Veins; the spirit of the rudder; there is the moon and his children, and the Sun and his (they are both masculine); there is a dim and awesome figure, the nearest approach to regal dignity in the poems, Tapio, God of the Forest, and his spouse Mielikki, and their fairy-like son and daughter Tellervo, "little maiden of the forest clad in soft and beauteous garments", and her brother Myrikki with his red cap and blue coat; there is Jumala in the heavens (Jumala whose name is used for God in the Bible, but who in the poems is usually a god of the air and clouds); and there is Tuoni in the earth, or rather in some vague dismal region beside a river of strange things. Ahti and his wife Vellamo dwell in the waters, and there are a thousand other new and strange characters for acquaintance—Pakkanen the Frost; Lempo the spirit of Evil; Kankahatar, the goddess of weaving—but a catalogue does not inspire those that have not yet been introduced, and bores those that have. The division between the offspring of the nymphs, sprites, and other beings (you can seldom call them Gods—it is much too Olympian) and the human characters is hardly drawn at all. Väinämöinen, most venerable of evergreen patriarchs, mightiest of culture-heroes (he is the God of Music in Esthonia), most human of liars, is the son of the Wind and of Ilmatar, daughter of the Air; Kullervo, most tragic of peasant-boys, is but two generations from a swan.

I give you just this jumble of gods great and small to give you some impression of the delightful variety of the Land of Heroes. If you are not of the temper, or think you are not, for getting on with these divine and heroic personages, I assure you, as I did before, that they behave most charmingly: they all obey the great rule of the game in the Kalevala, which is to tell at least three lies before imparting accurate information, however trivial. It seems to have become a formula or polite behaviour, for no one in the Kalevala is believed until his fourth statement (which he modestly prefaces with "all the truth I now will tell you, though at first I lied a little".) So much for the religion (if you can call it such) and the imaginary background.

The real scenery of the poems, the place of most of the action is Suomi, the Marshland—Finland as we now call it—which the Finns themselves often name the Land of Ten Thousand Lakes. Short of going there, I imagine one could scarcely be made to see the land more vividly than by reading the Kalevala—the land of a century ago or more, at any rate, if not a land ravaged by modern progress. The poems are instinct with the love of it, of its bogs and wide marshes in which stand islands as it were formed by rising ground and sometimes topped with trees. The bogs are always with you—and a worsted or outwitted hero is invariably thrown into one. One sees the lakes and reed-fenced flats with slow rivers; the perpetual fishing; the pile-built houses—and then in winter the

land covered with sleighs, and men faring over quick and firm alike on snow-shoes. Juniper, Pine, fir, aspen, birch are continually mentioned, rarely the oak, very seldom any other tree; and whatever they be nowadays in Finland the bear and wolf are in the Kalevala persons of great importance, and many sub-arctic animals figure in it too, that we do not know in England. The customs are all strange and so are the colours of everyday life; the pleasures and the dangers are

{The typescript stops here, in mid-phrase at the bottom of the page. A hand-written comment in ink just below it notes: “[Text breaks off here]”}

NOTES AND COMMENTARY

sudden collapse of the proper speaker. That Tolkien was filling in for two collapsed speakers some five to ten years apart, while not impossible, seems stretching credibility. But since there is no evidence that this version of the talk was ever given, the opening sentence may simply have been retained from the earlier version.

literature so very unlike. Note that the word is now spelled with one *t*.

Keltic . . . Keltic. Another spelling idiosyncrasy. The word is conventionally spelled with a *c* as *Celtic*, but Tolkien may have been making sure of the pronunciation, for the *c* is hard, as in “cap.”

a no longer understood tradition. The 19th and early 20th century view of Welsh myth as seen in the *Mabinogion* was of a once coherent concept behind the stories what had been garbled and misunderstood over time, partly through the supervention of Christianity and partly through the limited acquaintance of Christian redactors with the original stories.

the catalogue of the heroes of Arthur’s court in the story of Kilhwch and Olwen. The Arthurian Court List is a “run” of some 260 names, some historical, some legendary, some alleged to be Arthur’s relatives, some obviously fanciful, such as *Clust mab Clustfeinad*, “Ear son of Hearer” and *Drem mab Dremhidydd*, “Sight son of Seer.” The recitation would have been a *tour de force* for the bard, as well as an evocation of a host of other untold stories.

Yspaddaden Penkawr. Yspaddaden “Chief/Head Giant,” is the father of Olwen, Kilhwch’s intended bride, and the tasks he assigns are not meant to test but to kill the prospective lover.

weird tales. This was the title of an American magazine of pulp fantasy fiction, first published in 1923, but not widely circulated in England. Tolkien’s allusion (if such it is) is likelier to have been to E.T.A. Hoffmann’s collection of stories, *Weird Tales*, translated from the German by J.T. Bealby and published in England in 1884.

(as Francis Thompson says) “none will again behold”. Francis Thompson (1859-1907) was an English Catholic poet, best known for “The Hound of Heaven,” which Tolkien admired. The lines quoted here are from the concluding paragraphs of “Paganism Old and New: The Attempted Revival of the Pagan spirit, with its Tremendous Power of a Past, Though a Dead Past” published in Thompson’s collection *A Renegade Poet*. Christopher Tolkien comments in a note in *The Book of Lost Tales* Part I, that Tolkien “acquired the Works of Francis Thompson in 1913 and 1914” (*Lost Tales I*, 29).

‘nostalgie de la boue’. Literally, “yearning for the mud.” Metaphorically, the phrase describes the desire, exemplified by the Romantic attraction to the primitive, to ascribe higher spiritual values to people and cultures considered lower than one’s own. The attitude was widespread in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, initiated by antiquarians, energized by the discoveries of archaeologists, and fueled by anthropological research into comparative mythology and philology, all of which encouraged the finding of value in the archaic and primitive for its own sake. The word *folklore*, with its condescending assumption that the “folk” are other (and less educated) than users of the term, illustrates the mind-set.

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